How to Study the Bible

Course materials adapted for instruction by Luke Johnston using existing Bible-study resources; original source credits retained.

Compiled teacher resource with supporting weekly teacher/student materials.

Full teaching files

How to Study the Bible - TEACHER - Millheim copy (Sep 9 2026)	*37 pages*
how to study the bible snapshot	*2 pages*
how to study the bible snapshot student	*2 pages*
how to study the bible student week 1 mbc	*10 pages*
updated how to study the bible teacher	*10 pages*
people group factor week 3	*2 pages*
week 3 teacher how to study the bible	*4 pages*
addendum 1	*2 pages*
dispensational how to study the bible lesson	*2 pages*
final teacher copy dispensationalism	*2 pages*
Pages from Millheim How to Study the Bible STUDENT	*2 pages*
addendum 2	*1 pages*
teacher copy how to study the bible week 5	*2 pages*
week 5 study how to study the bible	*2 pages*
addendum 3	*1 pages*
how to study the bible student week 6	*2 pages*
teacher how to study the bible week 6	*2 pages*
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How to Study the Bible continued

millheim student week 9	*2 pages*
teacher millheim week 9	*2 pages*
millheim week 10 student	*2 pages*
millheim week 10 teacher	*4 pages*
student week 11 how to study the bible	*2 pages*
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student week 12 final complete combined	*2 pages*
teacher week 12 final complete combined	*2 pages*

Teacher and student editions are components of this one portfolio entry.

How to Study the Bible

2 Timothy 2:15

Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.

This study will focus on **what the Bible says**.

Personal Bible Study Check-up Questions

Be honest…

1. Have you ever read the entire Bible all the way through?
2. How often per week do you spend **reading** your Bible?
3. How often per week do you spend **studying** your Bible?
4. When you study, do you understand what you are reading?
5. Do you think it is possible to understand the Bible?
6. What is the last verse in the Bible you memorized?
7. Do you have anybody that has helped you when you didn't understand a verse/passage from the Bible?
8. Do you feel blessed by God when you read and study His Bible?
9. Do you ever take time during the week to review your notes from Sunday's Bible messages?
10. Will you commit to spending time each day with God in the Bible?
11. Are you tired of me asking questions?



WEEK #1 Introduction

This is a very important study. These are foundational principles for all Bible reading and study. If you want something to last, you have to build on a solid foundation.

Because of the power of God's word, this will be an awesome opportunity to expose seekers of truth to the truth of the Bible.

- John 18:33-38, 19:9 – Pilate's question to Jesus…What is truth?
- John 17:17 – …*thy word is truth.*

Important for this Study:

- ✓ Get a notebook to keep all of your study sheets together
- ✓ Continue to reflect on the Personal Bible Study Check-up questions
- ✓ Pray for someone you know that would benefit from this study
- ✓ Ask that person and others to come in the following weeks

The Bible is no ordinary Book:

- Hebrews 4:12 – The Bible is alive. It discerns thoughts and intents. It cuts right to it.
- James 1:21-25 – The Bible is a true mirror.
- James 1:5-8; 4:2 – The Bible is God's Book, we must come to it humbly.
- 2 Peter 1:21 – Men were the pen God used to write it, but God was the author.
- Psalm 119:97-105 –
- Job 23:12 –
- Jeremiah 15:16 –
- Luke 4:4 – …*man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word of God.*



I. The word of God **TRANSFORMS** lives!

1. It is the agent which God uses to bring forth life.

Psalm 33:6-9	*By the word of the LORD were the heavens made…For he spake, and it was done…*
John 11:43	*And when he thus had spoken, he cried with a loud voice, Lazarus, come forth.*
1 Pet. 1:23-25	*Being born again…by the word of God…But the word of the Lord endureth for ever…*
Matt. 24:35	*Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away.*

Key Point:

IF God's word can make something out of **NOTHING**;

IF God's word can raise a **DEAD** man from a grave;

IF God's word can deliver the salvation of one's **SOUL**;

IF God's word will endure for ever and **NEVER** pass away…

THEN…we ought to…

- Pay close attention to it!
- Read it!
- Believe it!
- Study it!
- Memorize it!
- Obey it!
- Love it!
- …for the rest of our lives!!!

2. Consider the time in which we live.

Amos 8:11-12	*Behold, the days come…I will send a famine…but of hearing the words of the LORD:*
2 Timothy 3:1-7	*…the last days…Ever learning, and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth*
Daniel 12:4	*…the time of the end…many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased.*

Key Point:

The time of Amos is a lot like the time in which we live…materialistic, prosperous, swelling church attendance, but not many really know God, not many are preaching, and not many are **HEARING** the Bible...it's a famine!

The time 2 Timothy and Daniel prophesied about is now…

This is why WE *must* pay attention to what God says in His word!

II. Foundational principles of Bible study

1. The Bible overall is **NOT** difficult to understand. We make it difficult by **NOT** believing every word we read.

   2 Peter 3:16 *…in which are **some things** hard to be understood…*

   2 Cor. 11:1-3 *…as the serpent beguiled Eve through his subtilty…simplicity that is in Christ.*

   Gen. 2:16 *And the LORD God commanded the man, saying…*

   Genesis 3:1-3 *Now the serpent was more subtil…Yea, hath God said…* (He **questions** God's word)

   Genesis 3:4 *And the serpent said unto the woman, Ye shall not surely die:* (He **contradicts** God's word)

   Genesis 3:5 *For God doth know that in the day ye eat thereof…* (He **changes** God's word)

   Note: Why? Satan understands something…

   1 Thess. 2:13 *…when ye received the word of God…ye received it…as it is in truth, the word of God…*

2. Anyone can get a working knowledge of the Bible if they want it. There is **NO** special secret, **NO** magic formula. An education may be helpful, but it is **NOT** necessary. Knowledge of other languages can be helpful, but it is **NOT** necessary.

   The disciples were common men, not scholars.

   Mark 12:37 *…And the common people heard him gladly.*

   Rev. 2:6 *…thou hatest the deeds of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate.*

   Rev. 2:15 *…the doctrine of the Nicolaitans, which thing I hate.*

   God wrote the Bible to reveal truth, not hide it.

   Ps. 119:105 *Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path.*

   Ps. 119:130 *The entrance of thy words giveth light…*

   Prov. 6:23 *For the commandment is a lamp, and the law is light…*

3. The Holy Spirit teaches the Bible. God can and will use other instruments (preachers, Bible teachers, videos, CD's, books, commentaries, etc.), but all truth is imparted by the Holy Spirit. How much you learn depends **SOLELY** on your responsiveness to Him.

   Note: I will not teach you anything throughout this class series. What you learn will depend on your reliance upon the Holy Spirit to be your teacher as you – by faith – believe what the Bible clearly says.

   John 14:16, 26 *…But the Comforter, which is the Holy Ghost…he shall teach you all things…*

   John 16:7-13 *…Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth…*

   1 Cor. 2:9-16 *…but which the Holy Ghost teacheth; comparing spiritual things with spiritual…*

   Note: Only the Holy Ghost can reveal truth…

In this respect, God did not author a Bible that anyone could understand!

4. Why are there "rules" of Bible study?

   - There are rules to just about everything else …

     1 Cor. 14:40 *Let all things be done decently and in order.*

     2 Tim. 2:5 *And if a man also strive for masteries, yet is he not crowned, except he strive lawfully.*

     …governmental operation, traffic, medicine, mechanics, engineering, sports, cooking, nature (gravity), life (golden rule, etc.)…everything! Think about it…when people come to the living, eternal word of God, then we throw the rules out the window! No! This violates common sense and logic!

     2 Tim. 3:16 *All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine…*

     During this study, we will be looking at **15** basic rules (there are more)…these rules come from the Bible itself and just good, sound, common sense!

   - Note: The "official" title for the study of how to interpret the Bible is called **HERMENEUTICS**.

     It is the "science" of interpreting the Bible (how to study the Bible). It is a man-made term that is important to know for your own reference.

After reading and considering everything we have today, will you take a moment and make a personal commitment to the Lord Jesus Christ?

Personal Commitment to Christ

III. Basic rules of biblical study and interpretation

Fifteen factors to focus Bible study

#1 THE CONTEXT FACTOR

1. There is no understanding of the Bible without a proper understanding of **CONTEXT**.

Note: ***Every*** verse, ***every*** passage **MUST** be studied in light of its context…

This has always been a common problem.

Psalm 56:5 Every day they wrest my words…

Jer. 23:36 …for ye have perverted the words of the living God, of the LORD of hosts our God.

Matt. 22:29 Jesus answered and said unto them, Ye do err, not knowing the scriptures…

2 Pet. 3:15-18 …which they that are unlearned and unstable wrest, as they do also the other scriptures…

It will always be a common problem.

Acts 20:28-31 …shall grievous wolves enter in among you, not sparing the flock…

Note: If this was going on 2,000 years ago…how much more today!?!

2 Cor. 11:3-4 …For if he that cometh preacheth another Jesus, whom we have not preached…

2 Cor. 11:13-15 …And no marvel; for Satan himself is transformed into an angel of light…

1 Tim. 1:19-20 …which some having put away concerning faith have made shipwreck…

Biblical context is a factor by which God sheds light upon a subject through either near passages or remote details bearing upon the same theme.

Note: Every verse in the Bible has something that precedes it and something that follows it, except two verses, Genesis 1:1 and Revelation 22:21.

Never, never, never take a verse out of its setting and give it a foreign meaning!

Establishing biblical **CONTEXT** includes:

1) **NEAR** context

- ✓ The preceding **VERSE**(s)
- ✓ The following verse(s)

- ✓ The preceding **PASSAGE**(s)
- ✓ The following passage(s)

- ✓ The preceding **CHAPTER**(s)
- ✓ The following chapter(s)

2) **REMOTE** context

- ✓ The **THEME** of the particular book of the Bible the scripture is located in
- ✓ How that particular Book fits into the **THEME** of the Bible
- ✓ Always keeping in mind the **THEME** of the entire Bible

3) **OBSERVATION** of other important rules of Bible study

- ✓ Historical framework
- ✓ Ethnic division
- ✓ Comparing things spiritual with things spiritual
- ✓ Other critical details, etc.

This evening we will examine examples of near and remote passages…

Some questions to ponder: (think for a minute…)

Have you ever had your words or statements taken out of context?

- Removed from your intention?
- Taken away from your heart's motive?
- Stripped from your character?
- Used against you?

How did it make you feel?

- Hurt?
- Betrayed?
- Misunderstood?
- Angry?

How do you think God feels about His words being taken out of context?

Hold that thought as we look at some examples…

2. Some common examples:

Near Context *(These passages are often misunderstood because they have been removed from their proper near context)*

Matthew 7:1-2 -

WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: It is not teaching us **NOT** to judge but rather teaching us not to have a critical or judgmental heart towards others…and what happens to someone who does!!

WHAT IT IS TEACHING: It teaches us how to **JUDGE**!!

Galatians 5:4-

WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: That those who are already saved can somehow **LOSE** their salvation.

WHAT IT IS TEACHING: Those who are trusting in their works for salvation, are missing out on the very thing that saves them, **GRACE**! They have not lost salvation

or God's grace, but they have not remembered that grace in their lives.

John 6:56 -

WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: That Jesus somehow wants us to eat His **LITERAL** flesh and drink His literal blood! Jesus had just fed 5,000 people. Many were still following Him because they wanted a free lunch. Verse 66…and took their false doctrine with them!!

WHAT IT IS TEACHING: A spiritual principle – His **WORDS** are life!!

Acts 2:38 –

WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: How **GENTILES** in the NT church age are to get saved!
How **GENTILES** in the NT church age should speak babble!

WHAT IT IS TEACHING: What actually happened as a matter of **HISTORICAL** significance after Jesus ascended into Heaven to be with God the Father and answers the question for the Jews that had killed their Messiah – oh no – what shall we do?!?! It was a special "dispensation" of God's **SPIRIT** for the Jews that had rejected and killed Jesus Christ!

Remote Context *(Passages in these books are often misunderstood because they have been removed from their remote context)*

1 Corinthians A **REPROVE** – a rebuke…it is more about what **NOT** to do rather than what to do – be careful!

Hebrews Some of the hardest passages in the Bible regarding **ETERNAL** security. It appears like you can lose your salvation?

- Remember – it was written to **HEBREWS** – who had a works-based religion!
- Remember – it is a **TRANSITIONAL** book in the Bible – like Matthew and Acts!

Observations *(Passages and chapters can be understood in light of the big picture painted by the order of the following books therefore establishing a broad overall doctrinal context)*

Example #1 Consider the big picture doctrinal context painted by the first 6 books of the Bible:

Genesis The book of beginnings…ends with God's man dead in a coffin in **EGYPT**…

Exodus God's people are redeemed by the blood of the **LAMB**…

Leviticus God's people are **JOINED** to God and the priests are established…

Numbers God's people wander in the wilderness of **UNBELIEF**…

Deuteronomy	God gave the law a second time…this time serve out of **LOVE** not duty…
Joshua	Joshua (**JESUS**) leads God's people to conquer the Promised Land…

Example #2 Consider the big picture doctrinal context painted by the order of the following books:

Ezra	The Jews **RETURN** to their land and the temple is rebuilt in Jerusalem…
Nehemiah	The Jews continue to return to their land and the **DEFENSE** network is rebuilt…
Esther	A Gentile bride is replaced with a **JEWISH** bride…
Job	There is a time of great **TRIBULATION**…
Psalms	King **DAVID** takes the throne from Saul (antichrist) and is King on the throne in Jerusalem leading worship…
Proverbs	The reign of the **WISDOM** of God – Jesus Christ – the living Word …

#2 THE PEOPLE FACTOR

1. There is no correct understanding of the Bible without understanding that the Bible is written to **THREE** types of people. This is often called the "ethnic division principle" – by those with higher education.

1 Corinthians 10:32-33

When God deals with mankind, He sees ***3*** different, unique divisions of people:

a. **JEW**

b. **GENTILE**

c. **CHURCH** of **GOD**

KEY – You must take into account to whom the passage was primarily written.

So…the old song goes…"All the promises in the Bible are mine, every chapter, every verse, every line"…No they are not! …aren't you glad – this Book promises hell to the lost – not me!

The entire Bible is broken down, directly and indirectly, into one of these three people groups…pay close attention!

These three people groups break down into the **TWO** types of people we are all familiar with in this world…

a. **SAVED** = **CHURCH** of **GOD**

b. **LOST** = **JEWS** & **GENTILES**

Although there is a very distinct difference in these two, both are equally lost!

The entire Bible is written **FOR** you; not all the Bible is written **TO** you: *(repeat until it sinks in)*

Note: All scripture is divinely inspired and has some application to your life (2 Timothy 3:16); you must determine whether it is direct or indirect…

Some examples:

a. James 1:1 (12 twelve tribes = **JEWS**; consider the author…)

James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, to the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad, greeting.

b. 1 Peter 1:1 (Strangers = **SAVED JEWS**, not Israel)

Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ, to the strangers scattered throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia,

2 Peter 3:1

This second epistle, beloved, I now write unto you; in both which I stir up your pure minds by way of remembrance:

c. Ephesians 1:1 ("saints", "faithful" saints…written to a church, **NOT** to an individual!)

Paul, an apostle of Jesus Christ by the will of God, to the saints which are at Ephesus, and to the faithful in Christ Jesus:

d. Isaiah 1:1; 13:1, 19; 15:1; 17:1; 18:1; 19:1; 34:1, 16 (pay close attention!)

e. Hebrews (The title gives it away – written to **JEWS**!)

f. 1 & 2 Timothy; Titus (written to individuals – church leaders – who are saved!)

g. Matthew - It is the Gospel with a uniquely **JEWISH** nature:

The **THEME** of this Gospel is: "The **KING** and His **KINGDOM**"

Chapter 1 - The genealogy of the **KING**. (1:1, 6)
Chapter 2 - The **BIRTH** of the King.
Chapter 3 - John the Baptist announces the King. *(John is the last OT prophet; Isa. 40)*
Chapter 4 - The **TESTING** and preparation of the King.
Chapter 5-7 - The constitution of the **KINGDOM**.
Chapter 8-9 - Christ presents His **CREDENTIALS** as the King.
Chapter 10 - The 12 apostles are sent forth to preach the gospel of the **KINGDOM** to Israel.
Chapter 11-12 - The **REJECTION** of the King and His Kingdom by the leaders of Israel.
Chapter 13-25 - The Kingdom enters a state of mysteries or **PARABLES** because of Israel's unbelief.

Matthew 24:13

Note: this is often misapplied to the church – Jesus is speaking to 12 **JEWISH** converts – still in **OT**!

- He is answering their question from verse 3, "Tell us, when shall these things be? and what *shall be* the sign of thy coming, and of the end of the world?"
- He is telling them of events of the Tribulation period. Look at verse 15, only 2 verses later: "When ye therefore shall see the abomination of desolation, spoken of by Daniel the prophet, stand in the holy place, (whoso readeth, let him understand:)"

KEY – part of understanding the *context* is taking into account the primary group of people to whom the passage was written.

Chapter 26 - The final night of the King.
Chapter 27 - The crucifixion and burial of the King. (Isa. 53)
Chapter 28 - The resurrection of the King.

NOTE: The danger of not understanding this point is expressed by Christ in Rev. 2:8-9; 3:7-9

Rev. 2:8-9 … and I know **the blasphemy of them <u>which say they are Jews, and are not</u>, but are the synagogue of Satan**.

Rev. 3:7-9 … I will make **them of the synagogue of Satan, <u>which say they are Jews, and are not</u>, but do lie**…

Question: Who, by their loud and clear doctrines, "say they are Jews and are not"?

Answer: Many cults/heretical groups do this, but we also can do it when we misapply passages/promises to Jews, to us as Christians

NOTE: Be careful – be aware – remember 2 Tim. 3:16 – don't tear out whole sections of your Bible!

#3 THE DIVISION (time) FACTOR

1. In order to rightly divide God's word, you must have ***GOD'S PERSPECTIVE*** ON HIS WORD:

   a. **The purpose of the Bible**:

   2 Timothy 3:16-17 - All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect, throughly furnished unto all good works.

   Doctrine = Teaching. Truth!
   Perfect = Complete. Fully **informed**.

   b. **The theme of the Bible: A King and His Kingdom**. This is chronicled in the Bible in 3 primary ways:

      1. The POWERS: God (Father, Son, Holy Spirit) and Satan – Matt. 28:19, 3:16-17; John 14:16-17; 2 Cor. 13:14; Gen. 3; Job 1; Isaiah 14:12-15; Ezekiel 28:11-19.
      2. The PLACES: Heaven, Earth, Hell – Gen. 1:1-25; Job 22:12; Ps. 14:2, 146:5-6; Matt. 10:28, 25:41; 2 Peter 2:4. (*Hell removed from most Bibles*)
      3. The PEOPLE: Jew, Gentile, Church – Rom. 2:9-10; 1 Cor. 10:32; Gal. 3:28.

   c. **The instruction of the Bible - God deals with mankind in different ways at different times**. It is critical to recognize how God divides His word. You must see how God has dealt differently with man over time. Some places in the Bible deal specifically with the Nation of Israel, other places, the Church. How can you know and recognize who and when? By **STUDYING**:

   2 Timothy 2:15 - Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.

   This is our key verse for this factor. It tells us 5 important things:

      1. What do we do with the Bible? **STUDY!** *(missing from most versions)*
      2. Why? To show ourselves APPROVED unto **God – NOT MAN!**
      3. HOW? **RIGHTLY** DIVIDING **– which indicates that you can WRONGLY DIVIDE IT!**

         Divide means to cut or to separate. An example of rightly dividing: What does this phrase say?

         GODISNOWHERE - GOD|IS|NOW|HERE - GOD|IS|NOWHERE

         Notice an improper division completely changes the meaning!

      4. The posture we must maintain – that of a workman **– it will take some work.**
      5. The result – We are NOT ASHAMED. There are people who will be ashamed as they stand before God for what they did to God and His word – 2 Cor. 5:8-10!

2. **HOW** does God divide His word?

   a. Times and seasons – Daniel 2:21; Ecc. 3:1-8; Acts 1:7; 1 Thess. 5:1; Heb. 1:1-2.

   b. Dispensations – Eph 1:10, 3:2-3; Col 1:25-26; 1 Cor 9:17.

   Dispensation = Distribution: The manner in which God deals out (dispenses) His grace/truth/law in specific ways to specific people. An economy or way of doing things; a certain administration. That which is dispensed or bestowed.

   - ✓ **NOTE**: It does NOT simply mean "a period of time." We may use times and dates to help us separate dispensations, but the time period does NOT define the dispensation, it's the other way around!

- ✓ The greatest and most obvious dispensation in the Bible: The Old and New **Testaments** - Hebrews 9:15-17. Consider what this means in each of the 4 gospels – Matt. 27:50-51!!
- ✓ Times and dispensations can be divided within a book, chapter, verse, or **PART** of a verse!!

  Isaiah 61:1-2 - Luke 4:17-21.
  Isaiah 9:6-7.
  Luke 1:30-33.

3. Locating the dispensations:

One of the easiest and most effective ways to find dispensations in the Bible is by looking at the **covenants** God makes with man. These lay out what God is going to do and how He is going to deal with man.

NOTE: Both covenants and dispensations often have more than one part to them and can overlap with others, skip time periods, or show up in the middle of others. Hence the reason a dispensation is not just a period of time.

Dispensation	**Covenant**	**Description**	**Scripture**
Eternity Past	None	Original creation. Lucifer & angels.	Gen. 1:1-2
Innocence	Edenic	Reconstruction of earth. Creation of man.	Gen. 1:3 – 3:24
Conscience	Adamic	Adam's lineage and sons of God.	Gen. 3:16 – 8:14
Human government	Noahic	Noah's flood and lineage.	Gen. 6 – 11
Promise	Abrahamic	Abraham's seed and birth of nation of Israel.	Genesis 12 – Exodus 19
Law-Kingdom	Mosaic	Moses leading the exodus, the giving of the law, the kingdom's rise & fall.	Exodus – Malachi
	Davidic	The line and Kingdom of David.	1 Samuel – 2 Chronicles
Christ's 1st coming	Davidic	2 Kingdoms. The start of the Church after Christ's death.	Matthew – Acts 7
The Church & God's grace	None	Transition of Church from Jew to Gentile oversight.	Acts - Revelation
Tribulation-judgment	None	A time of great trouble for the Jew.	Matthew 24-25, 1&2 Thessalonians, Hebrews, Revelation 4-19, Daniel 9. (Rapture of Church to 2nd coming).
Millennium	Palestinian	The 1,000-year reign of Christ on the earth.	Rev. 20; Matt. 5-7; Eze. 40:48; Zech. 14
Eternity	New	The new Heaven & Earth.	Rev. 21-22

4. **Key rules** for dispensations and rightly dividing:

   a. Do not take truth from one part of the past and read it into another part of the past – Gen. 1:29 vs 9:3.

   b. Do not take truth from the past and read it into the present – that is what some did in Acts 15:1-11 (7th Day).

   c. Do not take truth from the present and read it into the past – Rom. 8:9 vs Num. 11:29.

   d. Do not take truth from the future and read it into the present – Rev. 14:1-4 (JW's).

   e. Do not take truth from the future and read it into another part of the **future** – 1 Thess. 4:13-18 vs 2 Thess. 1:7-9.

      a. More examples

#4 THE APPLICATION FACTOR

All Scripture has **THREE** basic applications.

1) **HISTORICAL**

All Scripture has a single, obvious meaning rooted in the context of History, grammar and literary usage – thus the historical application.

a. **KEY:** The Bible is unlike any other book of religious writings in that it is primarily a book of **HISTORY** and its history is ***true***. Our God has chosen to work within the framework of time and space. It is important to note that the Bible has **NEVER** been proven to be ***historically*** incorrect. Mark it down – rest assured!

b. Every **PERSON**, **PLACE**, and **EVENT** is real. Everything we read actually took place *(or will take place)* and existed ***historically***, unless God tells us otherwise *(IE. parables or symbolism – example – "Hear the parable of the…")*

c. This historical application concerns: *Bible Characters (*people*)*
*Geography (*places*)*
*Chronology (*time*)*
*Experiences (*events*)*

KEY: You must **FIRST** understand the history of any given passage before you will properly comprehend other basic applications. If you misunderstand the history, you will violate the obvious and literal meaning of scripture.

2) **DOCTRINAL**

a. The word doctrine simply means "*teaching."* In every thing that God says, He is always interested in teaching us something.

b. The biblical usages of the word doctrine (it has a two-fold meaning or usage):

- God uses historical events to teach a general practical truth. This is also called the **PLAIN** teaching

- God uses historical events to teach a deeper truth. This is also called the **PROPHETIC** teaching.

KEY: God establishes His eternal truths through sound doctrine that always stands sure throughout the entire Bible.

3) **DEVOTIONAL**

a. This "*old"* book applies to my life today. Every book, chapter, and verse **APPLIES** to me right now, somehow. The question we must always ask is this,

"*How must I apply what the Bible says to my personal life?"*

b. All scripture has a ***devotional*** application - *2 Timothy 3:16-17* – memorize it!

Note: *This factor is also referred to as* personal *or* **INSPIRATIONAL** *application.*

God's purpose in Scripture – watch how this is defined in Scripture…1 Corinthians 10:1-12; Romans 15:4; Luke 24:27; *John 5:39; 46-47*

The Bible is a **PICTURE** Book.

…to see the pictures best you must put on your "**3**-*D Glasses."*

Some examples:

a. The Brasen Serpent *(Numbers 21:4-9)*

i. ***History*** – this is a true story – it really happened
ii. ***Doctrine*** – The **plain** meaning in the time was that any and all bitten by the serpents needed to look at the brazen serpent for healing. **Prophetically**, it pointed to the cross of Christ – 2 Cor. 5:21; Jn. 3:14-15
iii. ***Devotion*** – there is always a price to pay when you don't believe God…

b. Isaiah's Sign of Immanuel (Isaiah 7:14-16)

i. ***History*** – a child born in Isaiah's day served as a sign to Ahaz that Syria and Israel would soon be defeated
ii. ***Doctrine*** – In the day, the **plain** teaching was that a child would be born as a sign of their victory in battle. The **PARTIAL FULFILLMENT** pointed forward **prophetically** to the complete fulfillment in the virgin birth of Jesus Christ, "God with us" – Matthew 1:18-23
iii. ***Devotion*** – God keeps his promises, remains with his people, and can be trusted even when circumstances appear hopeless!

c. Leviathan (Job 41)

i. ***History*** – God describes an actual historical animal in **hyperbole** (poetic section of books, uses much figure of speech), in order to show Job the true source of his troubles since ch. 1.
ii. ***Doctrine*** – Job is facing a foe that is so awful, so strong, so wicked, that he would have understood as an actual animal in his day. God used the animal to give Job the picture. But he also gave **prophetic/deeper** language that Job would have known (as we do today) cannot apply to ANY regular animal. It was **prophetically** showing Job a description of the devil.
iii. ***Devotion*** – how to deal with trials, suffering and attacks from the devil!

d. This is **not** an exhaustive list. Remember "all" of the OT pictured Jesus and NT truths for us.
   i. The Strange Woman of Proverbs (Proverbs 5:3-7; 6:20-24; 7:1-5; Revelation 17:1-6); Abraham Offering Isaac (Genesis 22:1-14; Hebrews 11:17-19); The Passover Lamb (Exodus 12:1-13; John 1:29; 1 Corinthians 5:7); Noah and the Flood (Genesis 6-8; Matthew 24:37-39); Jonah and the Great Fish (Jonah 1:17-2:10; Matthew 12:39-41); The Manna from Heaven (Exodus 16:4-18; John 6:32-35); Water from the Rock (Exodus 17:1-6; 1 Corinthians 10:4); Adam as a Picture of Christ (Genesis 3; Romans 5:12-19; 1 Corinthians 15:45-49)

**** WARNING ****
This Bible study factor is not to be confused with the **ABSTRACT** method of Bible study developed by the epitome of all false teachers, *Adamantius Origen*. He developed what is known as the "*Allegorical method of Bible Study"...*

It is a method of reasoning that draws everything down to a metaphorical, figurative, or symbolic perspective. The danger, when applied as a method of Bible study, is that any passage is subject to the feelings or personal perspectives of the reader. This leaves the passage open for assorted types of interpretation that likely have nothing to do with what God is actually imparting. Who cares what someone thinks it means…what does it **SAY**! Be careful of Bible studies that go…read a verse then say," What do you think it means?"

KEY: The Bible says what it means, and means what it says. Anytime we apply the three basic applications to scripture, we must allow the biblical **TEXTS** to dictate the clear meaning.

#5 THE INDIVIDUAL WORD FACTOR

1. God has chosen every **EVENT** and every individual **WORD** in the Bible for a specific purpose.

   a. John 20:30-31; 21:24-25

   KEY: If there was a multitude of other things Jesus said and did events), we must ***have the most important*** things preserved for us in the Bible!!

   b. Every word of God is ***key*** as opposed to man's interpretation of God's intended thoughts, message, concepts and ideals. (Deut. 4:2; Deut. 6:6; Deut. 8:3; Ps. 12:6-7; Ps. 119:89, 160; Prov. 30:5-6; Jer. 26:2; Matt. 4:4; Matt. 5:18; Matt. 24:35; Luke 16:17; Rev. 22:18-19)

   KEY: The key to the word of God, is the **words of God**
   KEY: This is why God does not want us to **ADD**, subtract, or **CHANGE** His perfect word!!

2. It is the **WORDS** that are most important! The Bible does not just contain the words of God; the Bible is the pure word of God that will last forever (all of it…cover to cover)! – Psalm 12:6-7

   NOTE: This is in direct opposition to a belief system called Neo-Orthodoxy within theological circles which says that the ***thoughts*** are what really count! These so-called scholars proclaim that it does not matter what God actually said as long as we get the main point…be careful when you hear that!

   These men by their own admission, do NOT use the Bible as their authority for translating, studying, or handling the Bible. They rely upon textual sciences, human philosophies, and NOT THE BIBLE

   * Remember – God did not write a Bible for just anyone to understand – but only for those who are indwelt by His Spirit. Not all Bible "scholars" even claim to be believers!

   a. Matthew 5:18

   Psalm 119 is what is known as an ***acrostic*** psalm. There are 22 Hebrew letters in the Hebrew alphabet. Each stanza in Psalm 119 begins with a letter from the Hebrew alphabet.

   "Jot" – Psalm 119:73

   "Tittle" – Psalm 119:25 & 153

   b. In modern bible versions, precise words are ***admittedly*** abandoned for the flow of thoughts and concepts for readability's sake. Words are replaced/changed without thought of preservation. This is known in textual criticism as "***dynamic equivalence***"

      i. ***Leland Ryken (PhD) professor of English at Wheaton College***: "Dynamic equivalence is popularly known as a thought-for-thought translation instead of a word-for-word translation."[1]

3. **KEY:** God preserved every word in English in the King James Bible – exactly the way He intended …

   Some Examples:

   ✓ Hebrews 4:8; Acts 7:45 "Jesus" vs. "Joshua"

   - This is a "***transliteration***" that when translated exactly, word for word, teaches us a deep (doctrinal) truth of the Old Testament!

[1] Leland Ryken, *Choosing a Bible: Understanding Bible Translation Differences* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway Books, 2005), 7.

NOTICE: Just **ONE** word makes a BIG difference!!!

- ✓ John 1:1 "**A**" (many bible translations add this word; JW's infamously)
- ✓ John 7:8 "**yet**" (many bible translations remove this word)
- ✓ Acts 12:4 "**Easter**" (many bible translations change this word to "Passover")
- ✓ 2 Timothy 2:15 "**dividing**" (changed to "handling" or "teaching" in many versions)
- ✓ 1 Cor. 1:18 "**being**" (many bible translations add this word")
- ✓ Genesis 3:4 "**not**" (the original update to God's word: "thou shalt surely die." (Gen. 2:14)
- ✓ *This is NOT an exhaustive list of all examples. There are countless examples where every word added, subtracted, or changed makes a difference when studying the Bible. It is inevitable that when words are not the same, meanings change; hence God's warnings.*

4. God uses key words and phrases

- ✓ God uses key words and phrases in the Bible consistently to communicate truth…
- ✓ They establish contexts and provide ***keys*** for comparing scripture with scripture

Some examples:

- That day; The day; the day of the **LORD** …begins with Rapture and ends with close of Millennium
- **THOSE** days; woman in travail; time of Jacob's Trouble…all references to the Tribulation Period
- **LIKE** and **AS** (similes) are key words God uses to demonstrate deeper understanding of something
  - ✓ Luke 17:26-30
  - ✓ 1 John 3:2 - *Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be* **like** *him; for we shall see him* **as** *he is.*
  - ✓ Eph. 5:25 - *Husbands, love your wives, even* ***as*** *Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it*
  - ✓ Matthew 10:16
- **YE/YOU VS. THEE/THOU;** "ye" in the Bible is plural while "thee/thou" are singular (ex. Luke 22:31-32)
- Law of First Mention; the Bible study principle that the first time God uses a word, he defines it and establishes its meaning for the rest of scripture. If words are changed throughout to get the "ideas/thoughts", then this definition is easily lost (ex. "lovest" in Gen. 22:2; "worship" in Gen. 22:5)

FINAL THOUGHTS

- If we will approach the Bible with the attitude that **every word** is important, that **every word** is in place on purpose, and that **every word** is in fact the word of God…

  …it will change **what we see** and **what we UNDERSTAND**!!

- 1 Thessalonians 2:13 – *For this cause also thank we God without ceasing, because,* ***when ye received the word of God*** *which ye heard of us, ye received it not as the word of men, but as it is in truth,* ***the word of God****, which* ***effectually worketh*** *also in you that believe.*

#6 THE COMPARISON FACTOR

1. The Bible is of no **PRIVATE** interpretation. All interpretations must be done by comparing **SCRIPTURE** with **SCRIPTURE**.

   a. No private interpretations – 2 Peter 1:20

      NOTE: Verse 20 clearly teaches us that the Bible is of ***no private interpretation***!

      - Whether we like it or not…
      - No matter what anybody else says…

      KEY: In a literal sense, this destroys the argument of all those who **hide behind** the saying…

      …"Well, that's just **your** interpretation."

      At issue is not your interpretation or mine, but rather **the interpretation of the Author** of the Bible – the **HOLY SPIRIT**.

      Example – Who would be the best person to interpret a letter from me to you? **ME (AUTHOR)**

   b. Proper interpretation comes by comparing **spiritual** things with **spiritual** things– 1 Corinthians 2:1-14

      - Vs 1-8 Paul explains the contrast between man's wisdom and God's wisdom as revealed in His word
      - Vs 9-12 Even the "*deep things of God"* are revealed to those who possess His Spirit.
      - Vs 13 Comparing spiritual things with spiritual things is how the Holy Spirit teaches us.
      - Vs 14 The Word of God cannot be understood by mere human reasoning alone.

      NOTE: This is why the Bible is not meant to be read in the common "lingo" of any given day/age. It is meant to record God's exact words, that we are meant to study. The truth of the Bible is spiritually discerned as we **COMPARE** scripture with scripture (Romans 7:14; John 6:63). And this is only done effectively through the use of the exact words that God says.

      KEY: There comes a time in **serious study of the Bible**, to rightly divide the Scripture and pay due diligence to **every word**. That is the time to make certain you have a Bible that is not going to be dropping "jots" or "tittles" and removing the road signs and **landmarks!**

   c. God emphasizes the importance of two or three witnesses.

      NOTE: Having more than one witness/testimony to determine an unknown difficulty was established long ago by God! (2 Corinthians 13:1; Deuteronomy 19:15; Numbers 35:30)

   d. How cross referencing works – Isaiah 28:9-10, 13

      KEY: The best commentary on the Bible is the **BIBLE** itself, not our personal opinions.

      - To become proficient at understanding the Bible, we **MUST** exercise ourselves in the use of cross-referencing (e.g. – *study to shew thyself approved unto God*); tracking words and phrases throughout the Bible through the use of a **concordance** (hardback, online, on phone, etc.), through tools such as ***Treasury of Scripture Knowledge*** (hardback, online, on phone,

etc.)**,** and by **taking notes**.

- With today's technology, we have more capabilities at our fingertips than any other people throughout the course of human history!
- Remember, studying in this manner (comparing scripture with scripture) is how we're told to understand exactly what God is communicating to us…
- This is how we avoid our own personal opinions and private interpretations…
- Don't miss this critical **RULE** of Bible study…The Bible is of no private interpretation. All interpretations must be done by comparing scripture with scripture.
- Jesus, Paul, and the NT writers modeled use of this rule of Bible study when they would say **IT IS WRITTEN**…

2. An illustration of this Bible study factor:

a. **Revelation 4:1-4**

What is this event? What is going on? **When we get context of the book, study every word, and compare scripture with scripture: we don't have to guess!**

What does the Bible say? …let's compare scripture with scripture…

- **1 Corinthians 15:51–54**
  The Lord calls, a trumpet sounds, and in a single moment, someone is raised in a spiritual body
- **1 Thessalonians 4:13–18**
  A voice yells, a trumpet sounds, and immediately we are "caught up" to be in the presense of the Lord forever!
  - These all describe **the rapture** The book of Revelation is the only definitive place in the New Testament that gives us the timeline of the rapture.

b. **Genesis 3:1-15**

NOTE: The devil tries to hide his identity all over the Bible, but we can identify him!

- **Revelation 12:9**
  He is called a dragon, that old serpent, the Devil, Satan.
- **Revelation 20:2**
  He is called a dragon, that old serpent, the Devil, Satan…AGAIN!

b. **Leaven**

- **Hipocrisy** (Luke 12:1)
- **Bad/False Doctrine** (Matt. 16:6, 11-12)
- **Negative** (Exod. 12:15–20; 13:3–7; 23:18; 34:25; Lev. 2:11; 6:17; 10:12; Deut. 16:3–4; Amos 4:5; Matt. 16:6, 11–12; Mark 8:15; Luke 12:1; 1 Cor. 5:6–8; Gal. 5:7–9)

We must remember…

- The Bible is of **NO** private interpretation.
- **ALL** interpretations must be done by comparing scripture with scripture.

#7 THE CREATION FACTOR

1. The eternal truths of God that are revealed in the Bible can be enhanced by studying the **CREATION** which He has made. God is a master artist!

   - Psalm 19:1-4a The Bible clearly says the heavens declare His righteousness.

     NOTE: God says His creation **declares**, **sheweth**, **uttereth** His righteousness…creation has a **voice**, **speech**, and a **line** of communication so unique that **all** people of **all** languages in **ALL** time periods of earth's history can hear it – see also Psalm 97:6, Job 12:7-9.

   - Romans 1:18-20 The invisible things of God are understood by **STUDYING** the creation He has made.

     NOTE: Creation is referred to as God's **GENERAL** REVELATION of Himself because anybody anywhere **can** see Him in it (Rom. 1:20). According to God, nobody can **honestly** give excuse that they did not know the truth about God (2 Pet. 3:3-5…because of the testimony of creation, God calls them willingly ignorant). **The Bible** is God's **SPECIAL** REVELATION because it is written to those who **want** to know more about the God that they see in Creation and what His great plan is for man. The Bible and creation work hand-in-hand together proclaiming the truths of God.

     According to Romans 1:20…

     a. No one has an excuse because of:

        1. **GENERAL** revelation — It is general because creation is observable by everyone

        2. **SPECIAL** revelation — The Bible – God is always faithful to send a missionary

        NOTE: The "pigmy" or the lost multitudes in India, etc. are all included in this category…

     b. We also find that creation reveals an attribute of God called omnipotence (*omni* = all, *potent* = powerful):

        1. Examples of God's power seen in creation – **TORNADOES, HURRICANES, TSUNAMIS**
        2. Examples of God's eternal power seen in creation – **STARS, SAND, GALAXIES**

     c. God had a pattern when He created everything...the pattern was **HIMSELF**.

        The Godhead = the trinity = 3 (Father, Son, Holy Spirit)

        NOTE: He is the pattern! (see below)

2. **Examples of the Godhead that CAN be seen in creation:**
   - ✓ An atom (smallest matter known) is made up of protons, neutrons, and electrons.
   - ✓ A human being is made of 3 parts according to the Bible: **body**, soul, and spirit – see Gen. 1:26-27.
   - ✓ Time is either past, present, or future. It also breaks down to years, months, and days. Each day has hours, minutes, and seconds. Every day has a morning, afternoon, and night.
   - ✓ Color breaks down to 3 primary colors: red, blue, and yellow.
   - ✓ The common states of matter are solid, liquid, or gas form.
   - ✓ Space equals height, width, and depth.
   - ✓ Reality has space, matter, and **time** associated with it.
   - ✓ Electrical charge is either positive, negative, or neutral.
   - ✓ Water (a basic compound) has 3 parts = H20 (2 hydrogen atoms, 1 oxygen).

- ✓ To make fire you need heat, fuel, and oxygen.
- ✓ There are 3 heavens according to the Bible: earth's atmosphere, outer space, and the 3rd heaven.
- ✓ Skin has a dermis, epidermis, and hypodermis.
- ✓ Teeth are made of the crown, neck/cervix, and root.
- ✓ A family consists of mother, father, and child(ren).
- ✓ There are 3 types of levers.
- ✓ There are 3 laws of **motion**.
- ✓ There are 3 dimensions to space/objects.
- ✓ A triangle is the strongest shape in creation.
- ✓ There are 3 God-ordained institutions: family, government, and the church.

3. **Examples of Bible principles/teachings that CAN be enhanced by observing/studying creation:**
   - ✓ **Wind** - John 3:8, Acts 2:2-4 = **A TYPE OF THE HOLY SPIRIT**
   - ✓ **Trees** - Psalm 1:1-3, Mark 8:24 = **A PICTURE OF A PERSON/PEOPLE**
   - ✓ **Grass** - Isaiah 40:7,1 Peter 1:24 = **THE SHORTNESS OF LIFE**
   - ✓ **Fog/Fog Breath**- James 4:14
   - ✓ **Clouds** - Matthew 26:64, Acts 1:11, 1 Thessalonians 4:17, Revelation 1:7
   - ✓ **Night** - Romans 13:1-11, 1 Thessalonians 5:2-5
   - ✓ **Rain** - Isaiah 55:10, Jeremiah 5:24
   - ✓ **Snow** - Isaiah 1:18, Mark 9:3, Revelation 1:14
   - ✓ **The Sun** - Malachi 4:2, Psalm 84:11, John 8:12
   - ✓ **Moon** - Job 25:5, Isaiah 60:1-3, Psalm 136:9
   - ✓ **Stars** - Revelation 1:20, 12:3-4
   - ✓ **Ants** - Proverbs 6:6-9, 30:25
   - ✓ **Fish** – Matthew 4:19, 17:24-27
   - ✓ **Deer** (Hart) - Psalm 42:1, Song 2:9, 17
   - ✓ **Rabbits** (Conies) - Psalm 104:18, Proverbs 30:26
   - ✓ **Rocks** - Psalm 18:2,46; 28:1; 31:3; 42:9; 62:2,6; 71:3; 92:15
   - ✓ **Gardens** - Matthew 13:18-23, Mark 4:14-20

KEY: After looking at some of the examples above, we are reminded of two very important words that will link the Bible to these examples in creation:

"LIKE" and **"AS"**

Why is this a Factor in Bible Study?: Rule #7 shows us that God uses the things that He made in creation to give us further evidence of the Bible. It is also important to use creation in witnessing because it is part of God's "general revelation" **seen by everybody, everyday**…there's no excuse…creation speaks to the lost and saved!!

#8 THE APPARENT CONTRADICTION FACTOR

1. There are **NO** contradictions in the Bible, only "apparent contradictions." Always give God and the Bible the benefit of the doubt. To say that there is an error or discrepancy in your Bible and then move on like it is no big deal is heresy in light of Ps. 12:6-7, Pr. 30:5, etc.

   FIRST Understand that this important conclusion is first reached by **FAITH**…believing that God's word is divinely inspired and without error. To those who believe, God will confirm His truth by demonstrating that there are **NO** genuine contradictions that cannot be resolved.

   NEXT Although our conclusion for this factor is reached by faith, let us be reminded that genuine faith always has substance and evidence - Hebrews 11:1.

   THEN Consider that God's use of over **40** different authors to pen the Bible over 2,000 years in different cultures, time periods, etc. is going to bring some differences in style and the way events are recorded.

   FINALLY Whenever you find an "apparent" contradiction, immediately apply the rules of Bible study that you know to draw the **RIGHT** conclusion.

2. There are **PURPOSES** for "apparent" contradictions in the Bible.

   - To give skeptics a lie to believe.

     Ezekiel 14:1-4, 9
     Isaiah 29:9-14
     1 Kings 22:8-28

     NOTE If you come to God with your own pre-conceived ideas, not at all sincerely interested in what God says (wanting to appear religious, etc.)…God will give you a lie to believe! This is not because God is a liar! It is because you were not willing to **BELIEVE** Him, but rather your own lie! Most Christians miss this…in counseling…they believe the world's ways instead of God's ways. Why? It appeals to and satisfies the flesh! (Isaiah 30:1-3)

   - To reveal hidden truth to the faithful believer.

     Matthew 13:10-23 – Jesus said that the purpose of the parables was to hide truth to unbelievers and skeptics and to reveal truth to those who believe.

     John 6 – Jesus teaches the disciples words that seem to contradict (John 6:53; Gen. 9:4; Lev. 17:10-11; Duet. 12:23) The **SKEPTICS** walk away, while the believers stay (even though they don't fully understand yet; Jn. 6:67-69). Only once they had done this, were they then later allowed to understand the full truth of the story (Mt. 26:26-28; Mark 14:22-24; Luke 22:19-20; 1 Corinthians 11:23-26)

3. Regarding the skeptics…

   - You will see/hear this accusation against the Bible often. Nine times out of ten when someone tells you there are contradictions in the Bible, they cannot show you one. So, ask them to show you one to prove it ... this will usually make them quiet on this accusation!

   - However, there is that tenth person…so let's look at a few "apparent contradictions" in the Bible…

4. Examples of some "apparent" contradictions:

a. **Proverbs 26:4-5** – Do you answer a fool according to his folly or not? How would you biblically figure that out?

b. **Exodus 20:13** (also Deut. 5:17)
Exodus 21:12-19 (*aka…thou shalt kill*)

Which is right? Do we have the right to kill or not?

Is this a contradiction in Chapters right next to each other, or is God empowering government?

See also Romans 13:1-4 in the New Testament!

c. **Mark 15:25** – According to this passage, Jesus was crucified in the **3rd** hour of the day.
John 19:14 – According to this passage, Pilate presented Jesus to the Jews who said "crucify him" in the **6th** hour of the day…and He was then crucified (that same day!)…Uh, oh.

You indeed need some deeper **study** to clear up this "apparent" contradiction!

The gospel of Mark is recorded using **JEWISH** time.

The Jewish day begins at 6:00 AM which places the crucifixion at 9:00 AM, which is the **3rd** hour of the **Jewish day.**

The gospel of John is recorded using **ROMAN** time.

The Roman day begins at 12:00 AM *(like ours does today)*. This places the trial of Christ by Pilate at 6:00 AM, which is the **6th** hour of the **Roman day**.

This time schedule works out perfectly (from different perspectives…Jewish/Gentile) and lines up perfectly as an accurate, detailed record of scripture.

It clearly demonstrates our factor tonight…that there are **NO** contradictions in the Bible…

…only ***apparent*** contradictions.

Key Points

- ✓ Have a right heart attitude toward God and the Bible.
- ✓ Always approach the Bible by giving it the **BENEFIT** of the doubt.
- ✓ Every apparent contradiction has a **SOLUTION**, even though you may not be mature enough or gifted enough just yet to find it.

#9 THE CONSISTENCY FACTOR

1. When studying the Bible, we must pay attention to the **CONSISTENCY** of God.

   - There is a consistency to layout, words, and principles of the **BIBLE**…because there is a consistent nature to our God!

     Col. 1:17 The laws and order we find in creation are consistent because of Jesus Christ. (Newton's laws of motion, Laws of Thermodynamics, gravity's pull, how atoms work, etc.)

     Heb.13:8 *Jesus Christ the same yesterday, and to day, and for ever*. (He is the Word!)

     James 1:17 *…from the Father of lights, with whom is no variableness, neither shadow of turning.*

     Malachi 3:6 *For I am the LORD, I change not; therefore ye sons of Jacob are not consumed.*

   NOTE This does not contradict the fact that God does things differently at different times (the Time Period Factor). These are two distinctly different points.

2. God's consistency and the "Law of First Mention"

   - It is very common for the **1ST** mention of something in the Bible to establish a truth or **PATTERN** that is ***consistently*** followed throughout the entire Bible. You will observe these truths and patterns illustrated in figures (*pictures*) and truth (*words*) ***throughout the scriptures***.

   - This Bible phenomenon has been nicknamed… "The **LAW** of First Mention."

   - Genesis is a key book for many *"First Mentions."* Here are a few examples:

     "The serpent and his attack" - Genesis 3:1-5 (first mention)
     - ✓ The serpent is consistently associated with sin and the devil (see also Rev. 12:9, 20:2).
     - ✓ The devil's main attack is always against God's **WORD** (questions/contradicts/changes).
     - ✓ 2 Cor. 11:3 – *"But I fear…as the **serpent** beguiled Eve through his subtilty, **so** your minds should be corrupted from the simplicity that is in Christ."*
     - ✓ John 3:14 – *"…as Moses lifted up **the serpent** in the wilderness, **even so** must the Son of man be lifted up"* (see Numbers 21)

     "*Babel* or *Babylon*" - Genesis 10:10; 11:1-9 (first mention)
     - ✓ The first mention of Babel or Babylon involves false **RELIGION** and is and will be just like the false religion that Antichrist will use to deceive during the tribulation period (Rev. 17:5).

     "*love*" - Genesis 22:2 (first mention)
     - ✓ The first mention of *love* in the Bible is associated with a loving father offering up his only son as a sacrifice. A New Testament word used as synonymously for love is **CHARITY!**

     "*worship*" - Genesis 22:5 (first mention)
     - ✓ The first mention of *worship* involves a man being tested and trusting God to do the super-natural. True worship is associated with deep personal **sacrifice** and **faith** leading to a life changing encounter with God!

     "Egypt"- Genesis 12:10 (first mention)
     - ✓ "Egypt is mentioned some 600 times in the Bible and its first mention is significant. It is mentioned first in Genesis 12:10 when we read that Abraham, faced with a famine in the Promised Land, "went down into Egypt to sojourn there." Egypt, when used in the Bible,

symbolizes the world: this world's system, human life, and society with God left out. In its wealth and wisdom, its politics and religion, its culture and magnificence, this world is a snare to the believer."[2]

- When seeking understanding or clarification about an issue in the Bible, always check the 1st time the word or subject is mentioned. This factor is a great key, but it does not unlock every door.

NOTE. God's consistency and the "Law of Progressive Mention": First Mention introduces the subject; Progressive Mention follows the subject as God adds more revelation.

- The Lamb is a perfect example: Genesis 22 introduces God's provided lamb as a picture; Exodus 12 develops this idea of substitution and blood; Isaiah 53 reveals the Lamb as a suffering person; John 1:29 identifies Him as Jesus; Revelation 5 presents the slain Lamb risen and reigning.

3. God's consistency and His use of numbers in the Bible:

- **Three** - Romans 1:20, 1 John 5:7 (see also rule #7 study sheet)
  - ✓ Three is associated with the **UNIVERSE** and the trinity.
  - ✓ Three also has significance with resurrection and the new life associated with Jesus Christ (**3RD** day).
- **Four** – Isaiah 11:12
  - ✓ Four seems to associate with the **EARTH**
  - ✓ Mark 13:27 – *"And then shall he send his angels, and shall gather together his elect from the **four winds**, **from the uttermost part of the earth** to the uttermost part of heaven."*
- **Five** - Genesis 5:5 (first mention)
  - ✓ Five IS associated all over the Bible with death – death, grave, beast, grave, Satan, devil, **JESUS**
- **Six** - Revelation 13:18
  - ✓ God emphasizes this one! Six is the number of **MAN**. Specifically, fallen man or man's incompleteness.
- **Seven** - Genesis 2:2-3 (first mention)
  - ✓ God finishes with creation and He rests on the **7TH** day. Seven is emphasized throughout the Bible as God's number for **COMPLETION**.
- **Eight** - 2 Peter 2:5
  - ✓ Eight is the number representing new **BEGINNINGS**. (Seven is the number of completion!)
- **Nine** - Genesis 9:1, 9 (first mention) – Noah commissioned to bear fruit
  - ✓ Nine seems to be a number God uses related to **FRUITFULNESS/FRUITBEARING**.
- **Ten** - Genesis 10:10 (The first **GENTILE** kingdom)
  - ✓ Ten is a number that represents **Gentiles**, or non-Jews.
- **Twelve** - Genesis 12
  - ✓ Twelve is the number associated with the nation of **ISRAEL** and Jews.
- **Thirteen** – Genesis 14:4 (first mention)
  - ✓ Thirteen is associated with **REBELLION**
  - ✓ "Number THIRTEEN is the number of rebellion and apostasy. Its first occurrence is in Genesis 14:4 – "'Twelve years they served Chedorlaomer, and in the thirteenth year they rebelled." In this verse, thirteen appears and proves rebellion and government resisted. Beginning at this point, and appearing throughout Scripture, thirteen suggests rebellion, sin, and disobedience."[3]
- **Forty** – Genesis 7:4 (first mention)
  - ✓ Forty is related to a time of being tested or **TESTING**.

CONCLUSION

We must look for and apply the **CONSISTENT** patterns God has established throughout the Bible as we study it. God is very consistent with His words, principles, and even how He uses numbers. Also, when seeking understanding or clarification on an issue in the Bible, always check the **first time** the word or subject is **mentioned**.

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[2] John Phillips, *Bible Explorer's Guide: How to Understand and Interpret the Bible* (Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel Publications, 2002), 127.

[3] J. Edwin Hartill, *Principles of Biblical Hermeneutics* (CreateSpace Independent Publishing Platform, 2015), 149–50.

#10 THE LITERAL FACTOR

1. Always take a passage **LITERALLY** until it is impossible to take it literally or if there is clear instruction from the scripture that we are dealing with **SYMBOLISM**.

- This is commonly known in Biblical Studies as the "**GOLDEN RULE**" of Bible study. It is typically stated this way, "When the plain sense of Scripture makes common sense, seek no other sense."[4] [5] [6]
- It is also important to remember that we can interpret the Bible literally, consistently only because of the foundational rules established earlier in this class. These principles cannot be ignored or passed over.

NOTE Many will say something is "symbolic" in the scripture as opposed to taking it literally, exactly as it is written, as an excuse to justify lack of understanding.

Matthew 13:1-23 **PARABLES** What is a parable? Verses 10-12; Jesus explains them!
- Jesus then interprets the symbols in **verses 18-23**, showing that it was all clearly meant as symbolism/not literal/imagery

Revelation 1:12-20 **SYMBOLISM**

Ezekiel 37:1-11 **SYMBOLISM**
- Ezekiel sees a valley full of dry bones. As he prophesies, the bones come together, receive flesh and breath, and become a great living army. God explains that the bones symbolize the whole house of Israel, pictured as dead and hopeless but later restored by God.

John 6:35, 53-63 **SYMBOLISM**

KEY Very few passages in the Bible are symbolic. Symbolism that does exist is usually clearly defined in the immediate context. *(Those not defined in the context can be defined elsewhere in the Bible by comparing scripture with scripture. Ex. – Rev. 12:1-5)*

2. Keep in mind that God **TALKS** to us, through the words of the Bible, just like we talk: *(God records real life)*

- **Figures of speech** - Gen. 4:10; Lev. 18:25; Nu. 14:9; Joshua 24:27; Prov. 18:2
  - *Figure of speech - Figuratively explaining something (IE. sunrise / sunset…Matt. 5:45; Mark 1:32)*
- **Sarcasm** - Judges 9:7-15; 10:14; 1 Kings 18:27; Job 12:2-3; 18:5; 2 Co. 11:16-19; Acts 2:13
  - Elijah clearly does not believe that they may have a god who is just sleeping or on a trip, he is mocking and using sarcasm. Job clearly does not believe his friends possess all wisdom and when they die, all wisdom will cease to exist (as evidenced by the context vs. 3)
  - *Sarcasm - cutting or taunting in order to aggravate or hurt someone's feelings; a mocking remark utilizing statements opposite or irrelevant to the underlying meaning.*
- **Hyperboles** - Gen. 33:10; Deut. 1:28; Judges 7:12; 2 Kings 19:24; Jer. 15:16; 1 Co. 13:1-2; 2 Co. 7:14

[4] Roy B. Zuck, *Basic Bible Interpretation: A Practical Guide to Discovering Biblical Truth* (Wheaton, IL: Victor Books, 1991), 146.
[5] John Phillips, *Bible Explorer's Guide: How to Understand and Interpret the Bible* (Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel Publications, 2002), 26.
[6] Charles C. Ryrie, *Dispensationalism*, rev. and expanded ed. (Chicago: Moody Press, 1995), 80.

- *Hyperbole - An exaggerated statement used for effect not meant to be taken literally.*

- **Satire** - Isaiah 44:14-17; Gen. 37:19; 1 Samuel 17:41-44; Eccl. 2:1-11; Matthew 23:1-33
  - *Satire - A literary work in which irony, derision, or wit is used to expose folly or wickedness.*
  - The events described are literal, but Isaiah presents them satirically to show the absurdity of worshipping something a man made with his own hands. The purpose is what we are to understand. He is not giving instruction on woodworking, but using this as a condemnation of making gods with mans own hands.

KEY POINT **Always** take a passage **literally** unless it is impossible to do so!

This factor **SIMPLIFIES** what you read and will increase your comprehension of the Bible!

#11 THE ATTITUDE FACTOR

1. Always be ready to **CHANGE** whatever you have been taught or you have believed when you find it goes **CONTRARY** to the Bible – James 1:22-25.

- John 3:1-18 **RELIGION** can **blind us** from what we should believe.
  - **o** Nicodemus was so religious, so entrenched in his beliefs and religion, that he was unable to see clear and simple teaching that was right in front of him. He was so wound up he was thinking ridiculous things! Jesus speaks to him in one of the simplest and strongest statements of the Bible about salvation in Christ. **Are we so religious that we are unable to see clearly when God wants us to change what we believe, when confronted with his word?**

- Mark 7:1-13 **TRADITION** can **bind us** to unbiblical beliefs.
  - o We can "worship" God in vain (empty, fake), when it is according to our traditions and not God's word. Worship is sacrifice and giving of ourselves to God completely. How sad is it that someone could waste their life, sacrificing it to God, all in vain, because it was based on tradition and not God's word. Many do it never knowing that they were doing it in vain.
  - o How do we fix this? Ask the question: "Is what I am doing/sacrificing for BIBLICAL? Or, is it a tradition of men? If it is not Biblical, ask, "Why am I doing this? Who is telling me to do this? God or man/tradition?"

- John 11:23-27 – God will **CHALLENGE** our beliefs.
  - o Jesus is speaking to Martha about the death of Lazarus and he tells her that "he is the resurrection and the life." There were many disagreements amongst the Pharisees and Saducees about the resurrection of the dead at this time in history. Martha was thinking in their terms, Jesus fixes it all and clarifies that HE IS THE RESSURECTION AND THE LIFE.

- Mark 10:17-26 – Sometimes we will choose not to believe. We know better.
  - o The issue in this story is an issue as old as time, and it is the basis of all sin in our lives and it is the killer of any fruit, any learning, and growth: PRIDE! The rich young man did not have a lack of knowledge of what to do; he clearly understood. He simply did not want to do it. Just as the Devil has no lack of knowledge of the power, glory, eternality, death, resurrection, etc.. of Christ; he simply will not bow his life to Him.
  - o Many have no problem comprehending what the Bible teaches, it is written in plain English for our understanding. However, our issue as mankind, is our unwillingness to submit ourselves to God's word and his will for us.

- Luke 6:46-49 – Our beliefs will determine the **FOUNDATION** and steadfastness of our lives.
  - o Those who hear and refuse to obey, their lives always are shaky, unbalanced, constantly collapsing, etc.. because they refuse to obey, even though they know what they are supposed to do. There is no harder life than this life as a runaway child of God (prodigal son).

- 2 Kings 22-23 – The example of good king Josiah and his crisis of belief.
  - o Judah had drifted far from God and had been living contrary to His Word. While the temple was being repaired, Hilkiah the priest found "the book of the law in the house of the LORD" (2 Kings 22:8).
    When the book was read to Josiah, he realized how far the nation had departed from Scripture. "When the king had heard the words of the book of the law, that he rent his clothes" (22:11). He immediately recognized that Judah was doing things against God and his word: "Great is the wrath of the LORD... because our fathers have not hearkened unto the words of this book" (22:13).
    Josiah did not defend what they had always done or their "tradition". He gathered the people and "read in their ears all the words of the book of the covenant" (23:2). Then he "made a covenant before the LORD, to walk after the LORD, and to keep his commandments" (23:3).
    After that, Josiah began removing the idols, false worship, corrupt priests, and practices that contradicted God's Word. When Josiah discovered that what he and his nation had been doing was contrary to Scripture, he changed it.

KEY #1 We must always line ourselves up to what the Bible **clearly SAYS**!

KEY #2 We must be careful not to make the Bible say what we want it to say!

2. Our **personal beliefs** are formed by our upbringing, societal pressures/teaching, and personal experience. The following are a few examples of issues the Bible speaks about that may challenge your own personal beliefs and actions:

✓ *Managing finances –*
✓ *Dating –*
✓ *Biblical relationships –*
✓ *Marriage responsibilities –*
✓ *Child rearing and discipline –*
✓ *Proper use of alcohol –*
✓ *Giving –*
✓ *Church service schedules –*
✓ *Attitudes/actions toward authority –*
✓ *Work ethic –*

3. Have an **HONEST** attitude toward God when you come to a crisis of belief with His word.

- Mark 9:23-24 –

NOTE Changes in our beliefs will cause changes in our **ACTIONS** and attitudes.

KEY Many people are not able to apply this factor of Bible study because they **do not** have a final authority. If you **do not** have a final authority, **YOU** become the final authority.

#12 THE CLARITY FACTOR

1. Never violate a **CLEAR** passage when trying to understand an **OBSCURE** (uncertain) passage.

    - There are obscure passages in the Bible – 2 Peter 3:16
    - Some passages are clearly **CLOSED** for now – Proverbs 25:2; Daniel 12:4, 8-9; Ephesians 3:1-7; 1 Pet. 1:6-12; John 16:12
    - A few examples:

    FAITH ALONE VS. WORKS

    Clear

    ✓ Ephesians 2:8-9; Titus 3:5; Rom. 10:9-10; John 3:16; Romans 4:5; Galatians 2:16; Romans 11:6; 2 Timothy 1:9

    Obscure

    ✓ James 2:24; Hebrews 3:6

    BAPTISM AS PART OF SALVATION PROCESS

    Clear

    ✓ John 3:16; Ephesians 2:8–9; Titus 3:5; Romans 4:5; Romans 10:9–10; Acts 16:30–31; 1 Corinthians 1:14–17; Acts 8:36–38; Luke 23:42–43

    Obscure

    ✓ 1 Peter 3:21; Acts 2:38

2. Key points to remember when you encounter an obscure passage:

    - There are always **many, many more CLEAR** passages about a subject than obscure ones!
    - Apply the rules of Bible study to find the clear meaning of any difficult passage. If you cannot get clarity on a verse or passage concerning the subject matter after applying the rules of Bible study, move on for now, give God the benefit of the doubt, and trust the clear verses/passages that you do understand.
    - Eventually, you will always find that whatever an obscure passage means will **NEVER** conflict with other scripture taken in context. (Ps. 12:6-7; Pr. 30:5)

#13 THE QUESTION FACTOR

1. Never base a doctrine on a **QUESTION**. Questions are designed to investigate, interrogate, and **EXPOSE** an answer. Sometimes questions in the Bible can be rhetorical to support an answer, but remember, they are questions, NOT answers. This rule is strongly connected to the CLARITY FACTOR, yet they are distinct.

    "Obscure passages must always give way to clear passages. Further, we must never build a doctrine on obscure or difficult passages. Everything essential to salvation or to Christian living is clearly revealed in the Bible. We have no need to resort to obscure passages to support a Biblical belief. One such obscure passage in the Bible is found in 1 Corinthians 15:29, where we read: "Else what shall they do which are baptized for the dead, if the dead rise not at all? why are they then baptized for the dead?" The meaning of this passage is the subject of considerable controversy. The Mormons have formulated a doctrine of baptism for the dead based on this passage."[7]

[7] John Phillips, Bible Explorer's Guide: How to Understand and Interpret the Bible (Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel Publications, 2002), 108.

- Many strange and heretical doctrines are based on **QUESTIONS** in the Bible, not clear teachings of God:

  ✓ Extremist views of predestination (Calvinism) are based on a series of questions – *Rom. 9:13-24*

  While there are many passages used by Calvinists, their main areas used for doctrine are questions!

  ✓ Heretical teachings concerning grace plus works are based on a series of questions – *Jam. 2:20-26*

  The James text poses a question…a question cannot be the foundation for something as significant as teaching the Christian's salvation and eternal life are based on grace + works.

  ✓ The bizarre Mormon doctrine *,"baptism for the dead,"* is based on a single question in 1 Corinthians – *1 Cor. 15:29*

Key Point When a sole verse or passage is a question, it will **NOT** be the foundation for any significant Biblical doctrine. Therefore, ***never base a Bible doctrine on a question***.

#14 THE CONFIRMATION FACTOR

1. Never base a particular doctrine on **ONE** verse or passage alone. God always bases Bible doctrine (His clear teachings) on more than one verse!

   - Anytime God establishes a significant foundational truth, He ***always*** confirms it in the mouth of two or three **WITNESSES** –2 Cor. 13:1; *Deut. 19:15; Num. 35:30; Isa. 28:9-10, 13*

     ✓ 1 Cor. 15:29 — As we have already seen, the strange doctrine of "*baptism for the dead"* is based on **ONE** lone verse in the Bible (and a question at that!). Where else is baptism for the dead ever mentioned? Nowhere!

     - 1 Cor. 13:1 — Is there a heavenly language that angels speak? Or is this just a figure of speech? It is a figure of speech because when we compare scripture with scripture, we find that angels speak in **HEBREW**!! When angels speak, people understand them!! What other verses support a heavenly angelic language?

     - Matt.16:18 — Does this verse establish that Peter was to be the first pope in Rome? **1.2 billion people** follow a leadership system based on this **ONE** single verse.
       - Peter is not presented as the Rock, Christ is (**1 Cor. 10:4; 1 Pet. 2:4–8; Eph. 2:20; Isa. 28:16**); Peter was married (**Matt. 8:14; Mark 1:30; 1 Cor. 9:5**); Peter called himself a "fellow elder," not the supreme ruler of the church (**1 Pet. 5:1–4**); Peter explicitly refused religious reverence from Cornelius (**Acts 10:25–26**); Peter was publicly rebuked and corrected by Paul when he was wrong (**Gal. 2:11–14**); Peter was not the final authority at the Jerusalem council. James gave the concluding judgment (**Acts 15:7–20**); Christ, not Peter, is repeatedly called the Head of the Church (**Eph. 1:22–23; 4:15; 5:23; Col. 1:18; 2:19**); The foundation of the church is not Peter alone, but the apostles and prophets, with Jesus Christ as the chief cornerstone (**Eph. 2:20; Rev. 21:14**); Paul wrote an entire epistle to the Christians at Rome and greeted many believers by name without mentioning Peter (**Rom. 16:1–16**); When Paul was imprisoned in Rome, he mentioned numerous fellow workers but never identified Peter as the head of the Roman church (**Col. 4:7–14; 2 Tim. 4:9–12, 16**).

   - Remember to always **COMPARE** scripture with scripture *(Factor #6)*.

Key Point If an unusual doctrine in a verse/passage is not found supported anywhere else in the Bible... leave it alone.

#15 THE MATURITY FACTOR

1. God is infinitely wise. We will **NEVER** completely understand God. We are on a **LIFE**-long mission to know God and understand/experience His ways more until the day we are physically glorified - Ex. 33:18-23; Phil. 3:9-17.

    - Isaiah 55:8-9 – If we could ever completely understand God, we would be His **EQUAL**!

    - If you find something you don't understand, try your best to get it, being careful not to violate any of the rules of Bible study. If you still can't understand it, don't worry about it. God reveals His word to us in progression... ***as we are able to handle it***. We must also remember a humbling fact…God will not **TRUST** us with more if we are not faithful with what we have now.

    KEY We must work to **LIVE** what we ***do understand***, and then wait on God for more – Phil. 2:12-13

2. Always keep John 16:12 in your thinking… *"I have yet **many things** to say unto you, but ye cannot bear them now."*

15 Factors to Focus your Bible Study:

1. The Context Factor
2. The People Factor
3. The Division (time) Factor
4. The Application Factor
5. The Individual Word Factor
6. The Comparison Factor
7. The Creation Factor
8. The Apparent Contradiction Factor
9. The Consistency Factor
10. The Literal Factor
11. The Attitude Factor
12. The Clarity Factor
13. The Question Factor
14. The Confirmation Factor
15. The Maturity Factor

FINAL THOUGHTS

1. A Few More Key Principles to Store in your Toolbelt

    a. **The Kingdom of Heaven Vs. The Kingdom of God**
        i. "The Kingdom of Heaven is Jewish, the Kingdom which God promised to the nation of Israel in the Old Testament and is a literal Kingdom with a literal king upon a literal throne."[8] (Matt. 3:1-2; Hos. 1:4; Acts 1:6-8; Rev. 11:15)
        ii. "The Kingdom of God is inclusive in character, including: all who in any period believed God, the seed of Abraham, The Church, All who believe after the Tribulation."[9] (Rom. 14:17; Luke 17:20-21; 1 Cor. 4:20; 1 Cor. 15:50; John 3:3-5)
            1. Beyond this, going back to our Every Word factor: Are God and Heaven the same? Do we pray to Heaven? Do we live in God when we die?
            2. The Kingdom of God is a spiritual, inward kingdom entered through the new birth.

    b. **The Law of Full Mention**
        i. We have looked at the Laws of First Mention and Progressive Mention, but this principle is, "That principle by which God declares his full mind upon any subject vital to our spiritual life. Somewhere in the Word, God gathers together the scattered fragments that have to do with a particular truth, and puts them into one exhaustive statement. That is his full mind concerning that truth."[10]
            1. Examples — **Resurrection** (1 Corinthians 15); **Restoration of Israel** (Romans 11); **Faith Examples** (Hebrews 11); **The Church** (Ephesians 1); **Principles of the Kingdom of Heaven** (Matthew 5-7); **Righteousness by Faith** (Romans 3-4); **Charity/Love** (1 Corinthians 13); **Spiritual Gifts** (1 Corinthians 12); etc.

    c. **The Repetition Principle**
        i. The principle by which God repeats something already stated, in order to add to it, or to draw close attention to it. It is never done to "waste space".
            1. Examples:
                a. "Verily, Verily" (Jn. 5:24, 25; 6:26, 32, 47, 53; 8:34) —The statement means, "Truly, Truly". When he says it twice, it is meant to tell us to listen very closely.
                b. The Gospels — Four accounts of the Life of Jesus, all written to give us a different perspective of His life, not simply wasteful repeating of the same stories.
                c. Revelation — Four accounts of the events of the Tribulation, leading up to Jesus Second Coming.
                d. Kings/Chronicles — Both give the same basic telling of the events during this time in Israel/Judah, but from a different perspective. Many have noted that 1 and 2 Kings is mankind's perspective of these events, while 1 and 2 Chronicles is God's perspective of these events.

2. A Few More Tools To Use

    a. **Recommended Books**: *The Keys of Bible Study* (Mark Trotter); *Principles of Biblical Hermeneutics* (J. Edwin Hartill); *Bible Explorer's Guide* (John Phillips); *The Treasury of Scripture Knowledge* (R. A. Torrey edition); *Halley's Bible Handbook* (Henry H. Halley); *Willmington's Guide to the Bible* (Harold L. Willmington)
    b. **Recommended Bible Study Software**: *Blue Letter Bible (website and mobile app); Logos Bible Software (desktop, web, and mobile); e-Sword (Windows, Mac, Android, iPhone, and iPad); and SwordSearcher (Windows software).*
    c. **Recommended Audio Learning:** Mark Trotter's *Keys of Bible Study* is also available as a free 13-session WordStrong audio course (wordstrong.me). Also, on Apple Podcasts *WordStrong* channel.

[8] J. Edwin Hartill, *Principles of Biblical Hermeneutics* (CreateSpace Independent Publishing Platform, 2015), 41.
[9] J. Edwin Hartill, *Principles of Biblical Hermeneutics* (CreateSpace Independent Publishing Platform, 2015), 41.
[10] J. Edwin Hartill, *Principles of Biblical Hermeneutics* (CreateSpace Independent Publishing Platform, 2015), 94.

I. **MAIN TEXT: 2 TIMOTHY 2:15**- “Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.”

a. What do we do with the Bible? **STUDY!**

b. Why? To show ourselves APPROVED unto **God – NOT MAN!**

c. HOW? **RIGHTLY** DIVIDING **–which indicates that you can wrongly divide it!**

d. The posture we must maintain – that of a workman **– it will take some work.**

e. The result – We are NOT ASHAMED. There are people who will be ashamed as they stand before God for what they did to God and His word.

KEY: Before applying a passage to ourselves, we must understand what God said, through whom He said it, to whom He said it, when He said it, and why He said it.

II. **THE REVEALER OF TRUTH**

a. **The Holy Spirit is the Teacher of the Bible.**

i. **John 14:26**: “The Holy Ghost...he shall teach you all things.”

ii. **John 16:13**: “The Spirit of truth...will guide you into all truth.”

1. God may use preachers, teachers, and books, but spiritual truth is ultimately revealed by the Holy Spirit.

b. **The Holy Spirit teaches by the words of Scripture.**

i. **John 17:17**: “Thy word is truth.”

ii. **1 Corinthians 2:13**: “Comparing spiritual things with spiritual.”

1. We have learned the best commentary on the Bible. Many people desire to find a commentary that can help them to understand the Bible and in this class, we looked at the ultimate Bible commentary… The BIBLE. It defines and explains itself! (comparing scripture with scripture.

iii. **Psalm 119:18**: “Open thou mine eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of thy law.”

KEY: Depend upon the Holy Spirit, but never separate His teaching from His written words.

III. **THE MAIN RULE OF BIBLE STUDY: BELIEVE THE BOOK!**

a. **Come humbly and willing to change** (James 1:21)

b. **Be willing to change what you believe (**James 1:22-25; Mark 7:8-13 Religious tradition can make “the word of God of none effect.”)

i. Never change the Bible to agree with your beliefs. Change your beliefs to agree with the Bible.

KEY: Do not ask, “How can I make this support what I believe?” Ask, “What must I believe because this is what God’s word says?”

IV. **SOME OF THE QUESTIONS WE ARE ANSWERING WITH THE 15 RULES OF BIBLE STUDY**

a. **What is the CONTEXT?**

i. What do the preceding and following verses, passages, and chapters say? What is the theme of the book? Where does the book fit within the Bible? How does it relate to the Bible’s overall theme of **a King and His Kingdom**? What kind of writing is it? Poetry, history, epistles, etc.. (Psalm 56:5; 2 Peter 3:16)

ii. We learned that the Bible is meant to be taken literally unless it cannot be. Like with obvious figurative language or when the context tells us it is not literal (parables, symbols, “spiritual” truths)

KEY: Never remove a verse from its setting and give it a foreign meaning.

b. **Who is SPEAKING or WRITING? And To WHOM was it written?**

i. **1 Corinthians 10:32** identifies three primary groups: “the Jews...the Gentiles...the church of God.”

1. Is the passage addressed to Israel, Gentile nations, or the church?

a. **James 1:1** is addressed “to the twelve tribes.”

b. **Ephesians 1:1** is addressed “to the saints...and to the faithful in Christ Jesus.”

ii. **KEY:** All Scripture is written **for** us, but not every passage is written directly **to** us.

c. **WHEN does the passage concern?**

i. Which “dispensation” does this passage concern? **A dispensation simply means: God deals with different people, in different ways, at different times.**

1. Is it before the Law, under the Law, during Christ’s earthly ministry, in the church age, the Tribulation, the Millennium, or eternity? (Heb. 1:1-2; 2 Tim. 2:15; Eph. 3:2)

a. Do not take truth addressed to one people or time and force it into another.

d. **What do the exact WORDS say?**

i. Observe every word. Repeated words, pronouns, verb tenses, connecting words, questions, and comparisons. (Proverbs 30:5; Matt. 4:4; 5:18)

1. Do not merely read what you expect the verse to say. Ask what EXACTLY does it say?

2. The Bible NEVER promises to preserve ideas, thoughts, doctrines, etc.. It promises to preserve words, every word, and even markings! God is interested in every word!

e. **What is the passage TEACHING?**

i. Every passage has three basic applications:

1. **Historical:** What people, places, times, and events are being described?

2. **Doctrinal:** What truth is God teaching?

a. **The Bible is FULL of pictures, deep truths, prophetic truths, etc.**. (Luke 24:27; *John 5:39; 46-47)*

3. **Devotional or inspirational:** How should this truth change my beliefs, attitudes, or actions?

ii. **KEY:** Establish the historical setting first, determine the doctrinal teaching second, and make the personal application third.

V. WHY LEARN HOW TO STUDY THE BIBLE?

a. We are commanded to **study** it **correctly** (2 Tim. 2:15; 2 Pet. 1:20)

b. It changes us and makes us who God wants us to be (2 Tim. 3:16-17; John 17:17; Psalm 119:9-11)

c. The word of God is our lifeblood; it is how we know God and what he wants from us (John 15:1-8; Matt. 4:4; 1 John 2:3-5)

VI. Salvation

a. Maybe you are in here and you don’t know God.

i. **Romans 10:17-** “So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.”

ii. You have heard the word of God today, and you can by faith receive Jesus Christ today and be saved.

iii. Romans 3:23; 6:23; 10:9,13

iv. Maybe you think, “I don’t understand the Bible when I read it. I never get anything out of it.”

1. Our teacher is the Holy Ghost. MAYBE, you just need to spend more time studying and exercising yourself in the word, or MAYBE you don’t have the teacher, the Holy Ghost living inside of you. When you receive Christ, your understanding will be opened up in ways you never thought possible!

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1. Is it before the Law, under the Law, during Christ’s earthly ministry, in the church age, the Tribulation, the Millennium, or eternity? (Heb. 1:1-2; 2 Tim. 2:15; Eph. 3:2)

a. Do not take truth addressed to one people or time and force it into another.

d. **What do the _____ WORDS say?**

i. Observe every word. Repeated words, pronouns, verb tenses, connecting words, questions, and comparisons. (Proverbs 30:5; Matt. 4:4; 5:18)

1. Do not merely read what you expect the verse to say. Ask what EXACTLY does it say?
2. The Bible NEVER promises to preserve ideas, thoughts, doctrines, etc.. It promises to preserve words, every word, and even markings! God is interested in every word!

e. **What is the passage TEACHING?**

i. Every passage has three basic applications:

1. **Historical:** What people, places, times, and events are being described?
2. **Doctrinal:** What truth is God teaching?
    a. **The Bible is FULL of pictures, deep truths, prophetic truths, etc.**. (Luke 24:27; John 5:39; 46-47)
3. **Devotional or inspirational:** How should this truth change my beliefs, attitudes, or actions?

ii. **KEY:** Establish the historical setting first, determine the doctrinal teaching second, and make the personal application third.

V. _____LEARN HOW TO STUDY THE BIBLE?

a. We are commanded to _____ it _____ (2 Tim. 2:15; 2 Pet. 1:20)

b. It changes us and makes us who God wants us to be (2 Tim. 3:16-17; John 17:17; Psalm 119:9-11)

c. The word of God is our lifeblood; it is how we know God and what he wants from us (John 15:1-8; Matt. 4:4; 1 John 2:3-5)

How to Study the Bible

2 Timothy 2:15

Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.

This study will focus on **what the Bible says**.

Personal Bible Study Check-up Questions

Be honest… ☺

1. Have you ever read the entire Bible all the way through?
2. How often per week do you spend **reading** your Bible?
3. How often per week do you spend **studying** your Bible?
4. When you study, do you understand what you are reading?
5. Do you think it is possible to understand the Bible?
6. What is the last verse in the Bible you memorized?
7. Do you have anybody that has helped you when you didn't understand a verse/passage from the Bible?
8. Do you feel blessed by God when you read and study His Bible?
9. Do you ever take time during the week to review your notes from Sunday's Bible messages?
10. Will you commit to spending time each day with God in the Bible?
11. Are you tired of me asking questions?

WEEK #1 Introduction

This is a very important study. These are foundational principles for all Bible reading and study. If you want something to last, you have to build on a solid foundation.

Because of the power of God's word, this will be an awesome opportunity to expose seekers of truth to the truth of the Bible.

- John 18:33-38, 19:9 – Pilate's question to Jesus…What is _____?
- John 17:17 – …*thy word is truth.*

Important for this Study:

- ✓ Get a notebook to keep all of your study sheets together
- ✓ Continue to reflect on the Personal Bible Study Check-up questions
- ✓ Pray for someone you know that would benefit from this study
- ✓ Ask that person and others to come in the following weeks

The Bible is no ordinary Book:

- Hebrews 4:12 – The Bible is _____. It discerns thoughts and intents. It cuts right to it.
- James 1:21-25 – The Bible is a _____ mirror.
- James 1:5-8; 4:2 – The Bible is _____ Book, we must come to it humbly.
- 2 Peter 1:21 – Men were the _____ God used to write it, but God was the author.
- Psalm 119:97-105 –
- Job 23:12 –
- Jeremiah 15:16 –
- Luke 4:4 – …*man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word of God.*

I. The word of God _____ lives!

1. It is the agent which God uses to bring forth life.

Psalm 33:6-9	*By the word of the LORD were the heavens made…For he spake, and it was done…*
John 11:43	*And when he thus had spoken, he cried with a loud voice, Lazarus, come forth.*
1 Pet. 1:23-25	*Being born again…by the word of God…But the word of the Lord endureth for ever…*
Matt. 24:35	*Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away.*

Key Point:

IF God's word can make something out of _____;

IF God's word can raise a _____ man from a grave;

IF God's word can deliver the salvation of one's _____;

IF God's word will endure for ever and _____ pass away…

THEN…we ought to…

- Pay close attention to it!
- Read it!
- Believe it!
- Study it!
- Memorize it!
- Obey it!
- Love it!
- …for the rest of our lives!!!

2. Consider the time in which we live.

Amos 8:11-12	*Behold, the days come…I will send a famine…but of hearing the words of the LORD:*
2 Timothy 3:1-7	*…the last days…Ever learning, and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth*
Daniel 12:4	*…the time of the end…many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased.*

Key Point:

The time of Amos is a lot like the time in which we live…materialistic, prosperous, swelling church attendance, but not many really know God, not many are preaching, and therefore, not many are _____ the Bible.

The time 2 Timothy and Daniel prophesied about is now…

This is why WE *must* pay attention to what God says in his word!

II. Foundational principles of Bible study

1. The Bible overall is _____ difficult to understand. We make it difficult by _____ believing every word we read.

   2 Peter 3:16 *…in which are **some things** hard to be understood…*

   2 Cor. 11:1-3 *…as the serpent beguiled Eve through his subtilty…simplicity that is in Christ.*

   Gen. 2:16 *And the LORD God commanded the man, saying…*

   Genesis 3:1-3 *Now the serpent was more subtil…Yea, hath God said…* (He **questions** God's word)

   Genesis 3:4 *And the serpent said unto the woman, Ye shall not surely die:* (He **contradicts** God's word)

   Genesis 3:5 *For God doth know that in the day ye eat thereof…* (He **changes** God's word)

   Note: Why? Satan understands something…

   1 Thess. 2:13 *…when ye received the word of God…ye received it…as it is in truth, the word of God…*

2. Anyone can get a working knowledge of the Bible if they want it. There is _____ special secret, _____ magic formula. An education may be helpful, but it is _____ necessary. Knowledge of other languages can be helpful, but it is _____ necessary.

   The disciples were common men, not scholars.

   Mark 12:37 *…And the common people heard him gladly.*

   Rev. 2:6 *…thou hatest the deeds of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate.*

   Rev. 2:15 *…the doctrine of the Nicolaitans, which thing I hate.*

   God wrote the Bible to reveal truth, not hide it.

   Ps. 119:105 *Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path.*

   Ps. 119:130 *The entrance of thy words giveth light…*

   Prov. 6:23 *For the commandment is a lamp, and the law is light…*

3. The Holy Spirit teaches the Bible. God can and will use other instruments (preachers, Bible teachers, tapes, CD's, books, etc.), but all truth is imparted by the Holy Spirit. How much you learn depends _____ on your responsiveness to Him.

   Note: I will not teach you anything throughout this class series. What you learn will depend on your reliance upon the Holy Spirit to be your teacher as you – by faith – believe what the Bible clearly says.

   John 14:16, 26 *…But the Comforter, which is the Holy Ghost…he shall teach you all things…*

   John 16:7-13 *…Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth…*

   1 Cor. 2:9-16 *…but which the Holy Ghost teacheth; comparing spiritual things with spiritual…*

   Note: Only the Holy Ghost can reveal truth…

In this respect, God did not author a Bible that anyone could understand!

4. Why are there "rules" of Bible study?

   - There are rules to just about everything else …

     1 Cor. 14:40 *Let all things be done decently and in order.*

     2 Tim. 2:5 *And if a man also strive for masteries, yet is he not crowned, except he strive lawfully.*

     …governmental operation, traffic, medicine, mechanics, engineering, sports, cooking, nature (gravity), life (golden rule, etc.)…everything! Think about it…when people come to the living, eternal word of God, then we throw the rules out the window! No! This violates common sense and logic!

     2 Tim. 3:16 *All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for* _____…

     During this study, we will be looking at _____ basic rules (there are more)…these rules come from the Bible itself and just good, sound, common sense!

   - Note: The "official" title for the study of how to interpret the Bible is called _____.

     It is the "science" of interpreting the Bible (how to study the Bible). It is a man-made term that is important to know for your own reference.

After reading and considering everything we have today, will you take a moment and make a personal commitment to the Lord Jesus Christ?

Personal Commitment to Christ

III. Basic rules of biblical study and interpretation

Fifteen factors to focus Bible study

#1 THE CONTEXT FACTOR

1. There is no understanding of the Bible without a proper understanding of _____.

Note: ***Every*** verse, ***every*** passage **MUST** be studied in light of its context…

This has always been a common problem.

Psalm 56:5 *Every day they wrest my words…*

Jer. 23:36 *…for ye have perverted the words of the living God, of the LORD of hosts our God.*

Matt. 22:29 *Jesus answered and said unto them, Ye do err, not knowing the scriptures…*

2 Pet. 3:15-18 *…which they that are unlearned and unstable wrest, as they do also the other scriptures…*

It will always be a common problem.

Acts 20:28-31 *…shall grievous wolves enter in among you, not sparing the flock…*

Note: If this was going on 2,000 years ago…how much more today!?!

2 Cor. 11:3-4 *…For if he that cometh preacheth another Jesus, whom we have not preached…*

2 Cor. 11:13-15 *…And no marvel; for Satan himself is transformed into an angel of light…*

1 Tim. 1:19-20 *…which some having put away concerning faith have made shipwreck…*

Biblical context is a factor by which God sheds light upon a subject through either near passages or remote details bearing upon the same theme.

Note: Every verse in the Bible has something that precedes it and something that follows it, except two verses, Genesis 1:1 and Revelation 22:21.

Never, never, never take a verse out of its setting and give it a foreign meaning!

Establishing biblical _____ includes:

1) _____ context

- ✓ The preceding _____(s)
- ✓ The following verse(s)

- ✓ The preceding _____(s)
- ✓ The following passage(s)

- ✓ The preceding _____(s)
- ✓ The following chapter(s)

2) _____ context

- ✓ The _____ of the particular book of the Bible the scripture is located in
- ✓ How that particular Book fits into the _____ of the Bible
- ✓ Always keeping in mind the _____ of the entire Bible

3) _____ of other important rules of Bible study

- ✓ Historical framework
- ✓ Ethnic division
- ✓ Comparing things spiritual with things spiritual
- ✓ Other critical details, etc.

This morning we will examine examples of near and remote passages…

Some questions to ponder: (think for a minute…)

Have you ever had your words or statements taken out of context?

- Removed from your intention?
- Taken away from your heart's motive?
- Stripped from your character?
- Used against you?

How did it make you feel?

- Hurt?
- Betrayed?
- Misunderstood?
- Angry?

How do you think God feels about his words being taken out of context?

Hold that thought as we look at some examples…

2. Some common examples:

Near Context *(These passages are often misunderstood because they have been removed from their proper near context)*

Matthew 7:1-2 -

WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: It is not teaching us _____ to judge but rather teaching us not to have a critical or judgmental heart towards others…and what happens to someone who does!!

WHAT IT IS TEACHING: It teaches us how to _____!!

Galatians 5:4-

WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: That those who are already saved can somehow _____ their salvation.

WHAT IT IS TEACHING: Those who are trusting in their works for salvation, are missing out on the very thing that saves them, _____! They have not lost salvation or God's grace, but they have not remembered that grace in their lives.

John 6:56 -

WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: That Jesus somehow wants us to eat his _____ flesh and drink his literal blood! Jesus had just fed 5,000 people. Many were still following him because they wanted a free lunch. Verse 66…and took their false doctrine with them!!

WHAT IT IS TEACHING: A spiritual principle – His _____ are life!!

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WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: How _____ in the NT church age are to get saved!
How _____ in the NT church age should speak babble!

WHAT IT IS TEACHING: What actually happened as a matter of _____ significance after Jesus ascended into Heaven to be with God the Father and answers the question for the Jews that had killed their Messiah – oh no – what shall we do?!?! It was a special "dispensation" of God's _____ for the Jews that had rejected and killed Jesus Christ!

Remote Context *(Passages in these books are often misunderstood because they have been removed from their remote context)*

1 Corinthians A _____ – a rebuke…it is more about what ____ to do rather than what to do – be careful!

Hebrews Some of the hardest passages in the Bible regarding _____ security. It appears like you can lose your salvation?

- Remember – it was written to _____ – who had a works-based religion!
- Remember – it is a _____ book in the Bible – like Matthew and Acts!

Observations *(Passages and chapters can be understood in light of the big picture painted by the order of the following books therefore establishing a broad overall doctrinal context)*

Example #1 Consider the big picture doctrinal context painted by the first 6 books of the Bible:

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Numbers God's people wander in the wilderness of _____…

Deuteronomy God gave the law a second time…this time serve out of _____ not duty…

Joshua Joshua (_____) leads God's people to conquer the Promised Land…

Example #2 Consider the big picture doctrinal context painted by the order of the following books:

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1. It is the agent which God uses to bring forth life.

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   - There are rules to just about everything else …

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     2 Tim. 2:5 *And if a man also strive for masteries, yet is he not crowned, except he strive lawfully.*

     …governmental operation, traffic, medicine, mechanics, engineering, sports, cooking, nature (gravity), life (golden rule, etc.)…everything! Think about it…when people come to the living, eternal word of God, then we throw the rules out the window! No! This violates common sense and logic!

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     During this study, we will be looking at **15** basic rules (there are more)…these rules come from the Bible itself and just good, sound, common sense!

   - Note: The "official" title for the study of how to interpret the Bible is called **HERMENEUTICS**.

     It is the "science" of interpreting the Bible (how to study the Bible). It is a man-made term that is important to know for your own reference.

After reading and considering everything we have today, will you take a moment and make a personal commitment to the Lord Jesus Christ?

Personal Commitment to Christ

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Fifteen factors to focus Bible study

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1. There is no understanding of the Bible without a proper understanding of **CONTEXT**.

Note: ***Every*** verse, ***every*** passage **MUST** be studied in light of its context…

This has always been a common problem.

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Note: If this was going on 2,000 years ago…how much more today!?!

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Note: Every verse in the Bible has something that precedes it and something that follows it, except two verses, Genesis 1:1 and Revelation 22:21.

Never, never, never take a verse out of its setting and give it a foreign meaning!

Establishing biblical **CONTEXT** includes:

1) **NEAR** context

- ✓ The preceding **VERSE**(s)
- ✓ The following verse(s)

- ✓ The preceding **PASSAGE**(s)
- ✓ The following passage(s)

- ✓ The preceding **CHAPTER**(s)
- ✓ The following chapter(s)

2) **REMOTE** context

- ✓ The **THEME** of the particular book of the Bible the scripture is located in
- ✓ How that particular Book fits into the **THEME** of the Bible
- ✓ Always keeping in mind the **THEME** of the entire Bible

3) **OBSERVATION** of other important rules of Bible study

- ✓ Historical framework
- ✓ Ethnic division
- ✓ Comparing things spiritual with things spiritual
- ✓ Other critical details, etc.

This evening we will examine examples of near and remote passages…

Some questions to ponder: (think for a minute…)

Have you ever had your words or statements taken out of context?

- Removed from your intention?
- Taken away from your heart's motive?
- Stripped from your character?
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How did it make you feel?

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How do you think God feels about His words being taken out of context?

Hold that thought as we look at some examples…

2. Some common examples:

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WHAT IT IS TEACHING: It teaches us how to **JUDGE**!!

Galatians 5:4-

WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: That those who are already saved can somehow **LOSE** their salvation.

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1 Corinthians A **REPROVE** – a rebuke…it is more about what **NOT** to do rather than what to do – be careful!

Hebrews Some of the hardest passages in the Bible regarding **ETERNAL** security. It appears like you can lose your salvation?

- Remember – it was written to **HEBREWS** – who had a works-based religion!
- Remember – it is a **TRANSITIONAL** book in the Bible – like Matthew and Acts!

Observations *(Passages and chapters can be understood in light of the big picture painted by the order of the following books therefore establishing a broad overall doctrinal context)*

Example #1 Consider the big picture doctrinal context painted by the first 6 books of the Bible:

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Numbers God's people wander in the wilderness of **UNBELIEF**…

Deuteronomy	God gave the law a second time…this time serve out of **LOVE** not duty…
Joshua	Joshua (**JESUS**) leads God's people to conquer the Promised Land…

Example #2 Consider the big picture doctrinal context painted by the order of the following books:

Ezra	The Jews **RETURN** to their land and the temple is rebuilt in Jerusalem…
Nehemiah	The Jews continue to return to their land and the **DEFENSE** network is rebuilt…
Esther	A Gentile bride is replaced with a **JEWISH** bride…
Job	There is a time of great **TRIBULATION**…
Psalms	King **DAVID** takes the throne from Saul (antichrist) and is King on the throne in Jerusalem leading worship…
Proverbs	The reign of the **WISDOM** of God – Jesus Christ – the living Word …

#2 THE PEOPLE FACTOR

1. There is no correct understanding of the Bible without understanding that the Bible is written to _____ types of people. This is often called the "ethnic division principle" – by those with higher education.

   1 Corinthians 10:32-33

   When God deals with mankind, He sees ***3*** different, unique divisions of people:

   a. _____

   b. _____

   c. _____ of _____

   KEY – You must take into account <u>to whom the passage was primarily written</u>.

   So…the old song goes…"All the promises in the Bible are mine, every chapter, every verse, every line"…No they are not!…aren't you glad – this Book promises hell to the lost – not me!

   The entire Bible is broken down, directly and indirectly, into one of these three people groups…pay close attention!

   These three people groups break down into the _____ types of people we are all familiar with in this world…

   a. _____ = _____ of _____

   b. _____ = _____ & _____

   Although there is a very distinct difference in these two, both are equally lost!

   The entire Bible is written _____ you; not all the Bible is written _____ you: *(repeat until it sinks in)*

   Note: All scripture is divinely inspired and has some application to your life (2 Timothy 3:16); you must determine whether it is direct or indirect…

   Some examples:

   a. James 1:1 (12 twelve tribes = _____; consider the author…)

      James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, to the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad, greeting.

   b. 1 Peter 1:1 (Strangers = _____ _____, not Israel)

      Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ, to the strangers scattered throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia,

      2 Peter 3:1

      This second epistle, beloved, I now write unto you; in both which I stir up your pure minds by way of remembrance:

c. Ephesians 1:1 ("saints", "faithful" saints…written to a church, _____ to an individual!)

Paul, an apostle of Jesus Christ by the will of God, to the saints which are at Ephesus, and to the faithful in Christ Jesus:

d. Isaiah 1:1; 13:1, 19; 15:1; 17:1; 18:1; 19:1; 34:1, 16 (pay close attention!)

e. Hebrews (The title gives it away – written to _____!)

f. 1 & 2 Timothy; Titus (written to individuals – church leaders – who are saved!)

g. Matthew - It is the Gospel with a uniquely _____ nature:

The _____ of this Gospel is: "The _____ and His _____"

Chapter 1 - The genealogy of the _____. (1:1, 6)
Chapter 2 – The _____ of the King.
Chapter 3 - John the Baptist announces the King. *(John is the last OT prophet; Isa. 40)*
Chapter 4 - The _____ and preparation of the King.
Chapter 5-7 - The constitution of the _____.
Chapter 8-9 - Christ presents His _____ as the King.
Chapter 10 - The 12 apostles are sent forth to preach the gospel of the _____ to Israel.
Chapter 11-12 - The _____ of the King and His Kingdom by the leaders of Israel.
Chapter 13-25 - The Kingdom enters a state of mysteries or _____ because of Israel's unbelief.

Matthew 24:13

Note: this is often misapplied to the church – Jesus is speaking to 12 _____ converts – still in ___!

- He is answering their question from verse 3, "Tell us, when shall these things be? and what *shall be* the sign of thy coming, and of the end of the world?"
- He is telling them of events of the Tribulation period. Look at verse 15, only 2 verses later: "When ye therefore shall see the abomination of desolation, spoken of by Daniel the prophet, stand in the holy place, (whoso readeth, let him understand:)"

KEY – part of understanding the *context* is taking into account the primary group of people to whom the passage was written.

Chapter 26 - The final night of the King.
Chapter 27 - The crucifixion and burial of the King. (Isa. 53)
Chapter 28 - The resurrection of the King.

NOTE: The danger of not understanding this point is expressed by Christ in Rev. 2:8-9; 3:7-9

Rev. 2:8-9 … and I know **the blasphemy of them <u>which say they are Jews, and are not</u>, but are the synagogue of Satan**.

Rev. 3:7-9 … I will make **them of the synagogue of Satan, <u>which say they are Jews, and are not</u>, but do lie**…

Question: Who, by their loud and clear doctrines, "say they are Jews and are not"?

Answer:

NOTE: Be careful – be aware – remember 2 Tim. 3:16 – don't tear out whole sections of your Bible!

John 6:56 -

WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: That Jesus somehow wants us to eat His **LITERAL** flesh and drink His literal blood! Jesus had just fed 5,000 people. Many were still following Him because they wanted a free lunch. Verse 66…and took their false doctrine with them!!

WHAT IT IS TEACHING: A spiritual principle – His **WORDS** are life!!

Acts 2:38 –

WHAT IT IS *NOT* TEACHING: How **GENTILES** in the NT church age are to get saved!
How **GENTILES** in the NT church age should speak babble!

WHAT IT IS TEACHING: What actually happened as a matter of **HISTORICAL** significance after Jesus ascended into Heaven to be with God the Father and answers the question for the Jews that had killed their Messiah – oh no – what shall we do?!?! It was a special "dispensation" of God's **SPIRIT** for the Jews that had rejected and killed Jesus Christ!

Remote Context *(Passages in these books are often misunderstood because they have been removed from their remote context)*

1 Corinthians A **REPROVE** – a rebuke…it is more about what **NOT** to do rather than what to do – be careful!

Hebrews Some of the hardest passages in the Bible regarding **ETERNAL** security. It appears like you can lose your salvation?

- Remember – it was written to **HEBREWS** – who had a works-based religion!
- Remember – it is a **TRANSITIONAL** book in the Bible – like Matthew and Acts!

Observations *(Passages and chapters can be understood in light of the big picture painted by the order of the following books therefore establishing a broad overall doctrinal context)*

Example #1 Consider the big picture doctrinal context painted by the first 6 books of the Bible:

Genesis The book of beginnings…ends with God's man dead in a coffin in **EGYPT**…

Exodus God's people are redeemed by the blood of the **LAMB**…

Leviticus God's people are **JOINED** to God and the priests are established…

Numbers God's people wander in the wilderness of **UNBELIEF**…

Deuteronomy	God gave the law a second time…this time serve out of **LOVE** not duty…
Joshua	Joshua (**JESUS**) leads God's people to conquer the Promised Land…

Example #2 Consider the big picture doctrinal context painted by the order of the following books:

Ezra	The Jews **RETURN** to their land and the temple is rebuilt in Jerusalem…
Nehemiah	The Jews continue to return to their land and the **DEFENSE** network is rebuilt…
Esther	A Gentile bride is replaced with a **JEWISH** bride…
Job	There is a time of great **TRIBULATION**…
Psalms	King **DAVID** takes the throne from Saul (antichrist) and is King on the throne in Jerusalem leading worship…
Proverbs	The reign of the **WISDOM** of God – Jesus Christ – the living Word …

#2 THE PEOPLE FACTOR

1. There is no correct understanding of the Bible without understanding that the Bible is written to **THREE** types of people. This is often called the "ethnic division principle" – by those with higher education.

1 Corinthians 10:32-33

When God deals with mankind, He sees ***3*** different, unique divisions of people:

a. **JEW**

b. **GENTILE**

c. **CHURCH** of **GOD**

KEY – You must take into account to whom the passage was primarily written.

So…the old song goes…"All the promises in the Bible are mine, every chapter, every verse, every line"…No they are not! …aren't you glad – this Book promises hell to the lost – not me!

The entire Bible is broken down, directly and indirectly, into one of these three people groups…pay close attention!

These three people groups break down into the **TWO** types of people we are all familiar with in this world…

a. **SAVED** = **CHURCH** of **GOD**

b. **LOST** = **JEWS** & **GENTILES**

Although there is a very distinct difference in these two, both are equally lost!

The entire Bible is written **FOR** you; not all the Bible is written **TO** you: *(repeat until it sinks in)*

Note: All scripture is divinely inspired and has some application to your life (2 Timothy 3:16); you must determine whether it is direct or indirect…

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The **THEME** of this Gospel is: "The **KING** and His **KINGDOM**"

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Chapter 8-9 - Christ presents His **CREDENTIALS** as the King.
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Note: this is often misapplied to the church – Jesus is speaking to 12 **JEWISH** converts – still in **OT**!

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Question: Who, by their loud and clear doctrines, "say they are Jews and are not"?

Answer: Many cults/heretical groups do this, but we also can do it when we misapply passages/promises to Jews, to us as Christians

NOTE: Be careful – be aware – remember 2 Tim. 3:16 – don't tear out whole sections of your Bible!

Addendum 1- How To Study the Bible- Rightly Dividing the Word

This is a list (not exhaustive) of some of the prophesies that we see were fulfilled literally, exactly as God promised they would be. We even see some of them being fulfilled in front of us in recent history. These give us confidence that God's promises are not to be "spiritualized", but rather are to be taken literally.

- **Israel would go into Egypt, be afflicted, and come out later.**

  Prophecy: Genesis 15:13-14.

  Fulfillment: Exodus 1:8-14; Exodus 12:40-41; Exodus 12:51.
- **Israel would be scattered for disobedience.**

  Prophecy: Deuteronomy 28:64; Leviticus 26:33.

  Fulfillment: 2 Kings 17:6; 2 Kings 25:8-11; Luke 21:24.
- **Judah would be captive in Babylon for seventy years.**

  Prophecy: Jeremiah 25:11-12; Jeremiah 29:10.

  Fulfillment: Daniel 9:2; Ezra 1:1-3; 2 Chronicles 36:20-23.
- **Cyrus would allow Jerusalem and the temple to be rebuilt.**

  Prophecy: Isaiah 44:28; Isaiah 45:1.

  Fulfillment: Ezra 1:1-4.
- **Messiah would be born in Bethlehem.**

  Prophecy: Micah 5:2.

  Fulfillment: Matthew 2:1-6; Luke 2:4-7.
- **Messiah would be born of a virgin.**

  Prophecy: Isaiah 7:14.

  Fulfillment: Matthew 1:22-25; Luke 1:26-35.
- **Messiah would come from David's line.**

  Prophecy: 2 Samuel 7:12-16; Isaiah 11:1; Jeremiah 23:5.

  Fulfillment: Matthew 1:1; Luke 1:32-33; Romans 1:3.
- **Messiah would enter Jerusalem on a donkey.**

  Prophecy: Zechariah 9:9.

  Fulfillment: Matthew 21:1-11; John 12:14-16.
- **Messiah would be betrayed for thirty pieces of silver.**

  Prophecy: Zechariah 11:12-13.

  Fulfillment: Matthew 26:14-16; Matthew 27:3-10.
- **Messiah would be rejected, wounded, silent before His accusers, killed, and buried with the rich.**

  Prophecy: Isaiah 53:3-9.

  Fulfillment: Matthew 26:63; Matthew 27:12-14; Matthew 27:57-60; Mark 15:28; 1 Peter 2:24.

- **Messiah's hands and feet would be pierced, and His garments divided.**

  Prophecy: Psalm 22:16-18.

  Fulfillment: John 19:23-24; John 20:25-27.
- **Messiah would rise from the dead without seeing corruption.**

  Prophecy: Psalm 16:10.

  Fulfillment: Acts 2:25-32; Acts 13:34-37.
- **Gentile world kingdoms would rise in order.**

  Prophecy: Daniel 2:31-45; Daniel 7:1-7.

  Fulfillment: Babylon, Medo-Persia, Greece, and Rome literally rose in history. See Daniel 5:30-31; Daniel 8:20-21; Luke 2:1.
- **Israel would return to her land after worldwide scattering.**

  Prophecy: Deuteronomy 30:3-5; Ezekiel 36:22-24; Ezekiel 37:21-22; Isaiah 11:11-12; Jeremiah 30:3.
  Modern evidence: Israel exists again as a nation in her land. This does not mean every restoration prophecy is complete yet, but it does show a literal national return exactly as the Bible said. They are still be become "born again" as a nation in the future.
- **Israel would return as a nation, but not before going through the judgment of God.**

  Prophecy: Ezekiel 36:24-28; Ezekiel 37:1-14; Zechariah 12:10; Zechariah 13:1.

#3 THE DIVISION (time) FACTOR

1. In order to rightly divide God's word, you must have ***GOD'S PERSPECTIVE*** ON HIS WORD:

   a. **The purpose of the Bible**:

   2 Timothy 3:16-17 - All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect, throughly furnished unto all good works.

   Doctrine = Teaching. Truth!
   Perfect = Complete. Fully **informed**.

   b. **The theme of the Bible: A King and His Kingdom**. This is chronicled in the Bible in 3 primary ways:

      1. The POWERS: God (Father, Son, Holy Spirit) and Satan – Matt. 28:19, 3:16-17; John 14:16-17; 2 Cor. 13:14; Gen. 3; Job 1; Isaiah 14:12-15; Ezekiel 28:11-19.
      2. The PLACES: Heaven, Earth, Hell – Gen. 1:1-25; Job 22:12; Ps. 14:2, 146:5-6; Matt. 10:28, 25:41; 2 Peter 2:4. (*Hell removed from most Bibles*)
      3. The PEOPLE: Jew, Gentile, Church – Rom. 2:9-10; 1 Cor. 10:32; Gal. 3:28.

   c. **The instruction of the Bible - God deals with mankind in different ways at different times**. It is critical to recognize how God divides His word. You must see how God has dealt differently with man over time. Some places in the Bible deal specifically with the Nation of Israel, other places, the Church. How can you know and recognize who and when? By **STUDYING**:

   2 Timothy 2:15 - Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.

   This is our key verse for this factor. It tells us 5 important things:

      1. What do we do with the Bible? **STUDY!** *(missing from most versions)*
      2. Why? To show ourselves APPROVED unto **God – NOT MAN!**
      3. HOW? **RIGHTLY** DIVIDING **– which indicates that you can WRONGLY DIVIDE IT!**

         Divide means to cut or to separate. An example of rightly dividing: What does this phrase say?

         GODISNOWHERE - GOD|IS|NOW|HERE - GOD|IS|NOWHERE

         Notice an improper division completely changes the meaning!

      4. The posture we must maintain – that of a workman **– it will take some work.**
      5. The result – We are NOT ASHAMED. There are people who will be ashamed as they stand before God for what they did to God and His word – 2 Cor. 5:8-10!

2. **HOW** does God divide His word?

   a. Times and seasons – Daniel 2:21; Ecc. 3:1-8; Acts 1:7; 1 Thess. 5:1; Heb. 1:1-2.

   b. Dispensations – Eph 1:10, 3:2-3; Col 1:25-26; 1 Cor 9:17.

   Dispensation = Distribution: The manner in which God deals out (dispenses) His grace/truth/law in specific ways to specific people. An economy or way of doing things; a certain administration. That which is dispensed or bestowed.

      ✓ **NOTE**: It does NOT simply mean "a period of time." We may use times and dates to help us separate dispensations, but the time period does NOT define the dispensation, it's the other way around!

- ✓ The greatest and most obvious dispensation in the Bible: The Old and New **Testaments** - Hebrews 9:15-17. Consider what this means in each of the 4 gospels – Matt. 27:50-51!!
- ✓ Times and dispensations can be divided within a book, chapter, verse, or **PART** of a verse!!

  Isaiah 61:1-2 - Luke 4:17-21.
  Isaiah 9:6-7.
  Luke 1:30-33.

3. Locating the dispensations:

   One of the easiest and most effective ways to find dispensations in the Bible is by looking at the **covenants** God makes with man. These lay out what God is going to do and how He is going to deal with man.

   NOTE: Both covenants and dispensations often have more than one part to them and can overlap with others, skip time periods, or show up in the middle of others. Hence the reason a dispensation is not just a period of time.

Dispensation	Covenant	Description	Scripture
Eternity Past	None	Original creation. Lucifer & angels.	Gen. 1:1-2
Innocence	Edenic	Reconstruction of earth. Creation of man.	Gen. 1:3 – 3:24
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Human government	Noahic	Noah's flood and lineage.	Gen. 6 – 11
Promise	Abrahamic	Abraham's seed and birth of nation of Israel.	Genesis 12 – Exodus 19
Law-Kingdom	Mosaic	Moses leading the exodus, the giving of the law, the kingdom's rise & fall.	Exodus – Malachi
	Davidic	The line and Kingdom of David.	1 Samuel – 2 Chronicles
Christ's 1st coming	Davidic	2 Kingdoms. The start of the Church after Christ's death.	Matthew – Acts 7
The Church & God's grace	None	Transition of Church from Jew to Gentile oversight.	Acts - Revelation
Tribulation-judgment	None	A time of great trouble for the Jew.	Matthew 24-25, 1&2 Thessalonians, Hebrews, Revelation 4-19, Daniel 9. (Rapture of Church to 2nd coming).
Millennium	Palestinian	The 1,000-year reign of Christ on the earth.	Rev. 20; Matt. 5-7; Eze. 40:48; Zech. 14
Eternity	New	The new Heaven & Earth.	Rev. 21-22

4. **Key rules** for dispensations and rightly dividing:
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   c. Do not take truth from the present and read it into the past – Rom. 8:9 vs Num. 11:29.
   d. Do not take truth from the future and read it into the present – Rev. 14:1-4 (JW's).
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      4. The posture we must maintain – that of a workman **– it will take some work.**
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2. **HOW** does God divide His word?

   a. Times and seasons – Daniel 2:21; Ecc. 3:1-8; Acts 1:7; 1 Thess. 5:1; Heb. 1:1-2.

   b. Dispensations – Eph 1:10, 3:2-3; Col 1:25-26; 1 Cor 9:17.

   Dispensation = Distribution: The manner in which God deals out (dispenses) His grace/truth/law in specific ways to specific people. An economy or way of doing things; a certain administration. That which is dispensed or bestowed.

      ✓ **NOTE**: It does NOT simply mean "a period of time." We may use times and dates to help us separate dispensations, but the time period does NOT define the dispensation, it's the other way around!

- ✓ The greatest and most obvious dispensation in the Bible: The Old and New _____ - Hebrews 9:15-17. Consider what this means in each of the 4 gospels – Matt. 27:50-51!!
- ✓ Times and dispensations can be divided within a book, chapter, verse, or _____ of a verse!!

  Isaiah 61:1-2 - Luke 4:17-21.
  Isaiah 9:6-7.
  Luke 1:30-33.

3. Locating the dispensations:

   One of the easiest and most effective ways to find dispensations in the Bible is by looking at the _____ God makes with man. These lay out what God is going to do and how He is going to deal with man.

   NOTE: Both covenants and dispensations often have more than one part to them and can overlap with others, skip time periods, or show up in the middle of others. Hence the reason a dispensation is not just a period of time.

Dispensation	**Covenant**	**Description**	**Scripture**
Eternity Past	None	Original creation. Lucifer & angels.	Gen. 1:1-2
Innocence	Edenic	Reconstruction of earth. Creation of man.	Gen. 1:3 – 3:24
Conscience	Adamic	Adam's lineage and sons of God.	Gen. 3:16 – 8:14
Human government	Noahic	Noah's flood and lineage.	Gen. 6 – 11
Promise	Abrahamic	Abraham's seed and birth of nation of Israel.	Genesis 12 – Exodus 19
Law-Kingdom	Mosaic	Moses leading the exodus, the giving of the law, the kingdom's rise & fall.	Exodus – Malachi
	Davidic	The line and Kingdom of David.	1 Samuel – 2 Chronicles
Christ's 1st coming	Davidic	2 Kingdoms. The start of the Church after Christ's death.	Matthew – Acts 7
The Church & God's grace	None	Transition of Church from Jew to Gentile oversight.	Acts - Revelation
Tribulation-judgment	None	A time of great trouble for the Jew.	Matthew 24-25, 1&2 Thessalonians, Hebrews, Revelation 4-19, Daniel 9. (Rapture of Church to 2nd coming).
Millennium	Palestinian	The 1,000-year reign of Christ on the earth.	Rev. 20; Matt. 5-7; Eze. 40:48; Zech. 14
Eternity	New	The new Heaven & Earth.	Rev. 21-22

4. **Key rules** for dispensations and rightly dividing:
   a. Do not take truth from one part of the past and read it into another part of the past – Gen. 1:29 vs 9:3.
   b. Do not take truth from the past and read it into the present – that is what some did in Acts 15:1-11 (7th Day).
   c. Do not take truth from the present and read it into the past – Rom. 8:9 vs Num. 11:29.
   d. Do not take truth from the future and read it into the present – Rev. 14:1-4 (JW's).
   e. Do not take truth from the future and read it into another part of the _____ – 1 Thess. 4:13-18 vs 2 Thess. 1:7-9.

Addendum 2

Matthew Henry Commentary on Job 41

"Whether this leviathan be a whale or a crocodile is a great dispute among the learned, which I will not undertake to determine; some of the particulars agree more easily to the one, others to the other; both are very strong and fierce, and the power of the Creator appears in them. The ingenious Sir Richard Blackmore, though he admits the more received opinion concerning the behemoth, that it must be meant of the elephant, yet agrees with the learned Bochart's notion of the leviathan, that it is the crocodile, which was so well known in the river of Egypt. I confess that that which inclines me rather to understand it of the whale is not only because it is much larger and a nobler animal, but because, in the history of the Creation, there is such an express notice taken of it as is not of any other species of animals whatsoever **(Gen. 1:21**, God created great whales), by which it appears, not only that whales were well known in those parts in the time of Moses, who lived a little after Job, but that the creation of whales was generally looked upon as a most illustrious proof of the eternal power and godhead of the Creator; and we may conjecture that this was the reason (for otherwise it seems unaccountable) why Moses there so particularly mentions the creation of the whales, because God had so lately insisted upon the bulk and strength of that creature than of any other, as the proof of his power; and the leviathan is here spoken of as an inhabitant of the sea (**v. 31**), which the crocodile is not; and **Ps. 104:25, 26**, there in the great and wide sea, is that leviathan."

Jamieson, Fausset & Brown Commentary on Job 41

"Leviathan--literally, "the twisted animal," A poetical generalization for all cetacean, serpentine, and saurian monsters (see on JF & B for **Job 40:15**, hence all the description applies to no one animal); especially the crocodile; which is naturally described after the river horse, as both are found in the Nile."

The Biblical Definition

In Job 41 we have a prideful creature whose "scales are his pride" and who is "a king over all the children of pride" (**Job 41:15, 34; cf. Isaiah 14:13-14; Ezekiel 28:17; 1 Timothy 3:6**), a king and ruler who "beholdeth all high things" (**Job 41:34; cf. John 12:31; 14:30; 16:11; 2 Corinthians 4:4; Ephesians 2:2, 6:12**), an overwhelmingly powerful being whom no man can tame, bind, defeat, or even safely provoke (**Job 41:1-10, 25-30**), of whom God says, "upon earth there is not his like, who is made without fear" (**Job 41:33; cf. 1 Peter 5:8; Jude 9**), a cruel being before whom "sorrow is turned into joy" (**Job 41:22; cf. John 8:44; 10:10; Revelation 12:12**), a hard-hearted creature whose heart is "as firm as a stone" (**Job 41:24**), and a terrifying, fire-breathing dragon whose sneezings flash light, whose eyes shine, and out of whose mouth "go burning lamps, and sparks of fire leap out" (**Job 41:18-21**). This creature is specifically called Leviathan (**Job 41:1)**; Psalm 74 connects Leviathan with "the dragons in the waters" and says that he has multiple "heads" **(Psalm 74:13-14**); Isaiah identifies Leviathan as "the piercing serpent," "that crooked serpent," and "the dragon that is in the sea" (**Isaiah 27:1**); and Revelation identifies the great red dragon with seven heads as "that old serpent, called the Devil, and Satan" (**Revelation 12:3, 9; 20:2**). Thus, the biblical descriptions fit together: the prideful king of Job 41 is Leviathan; Leviathan is the many-headed dragon and crooked serpent of Psalms and Isaiah; and the dragon and old serpent are plainly identified in Revelation as the Devil and Satan.

#4 THE APPLICATION FACTOR

All Scripture has **THREE** basic applications.

1) **HISTORICAL**

All Scripture has a single, obvious meaning rooted in the context of History, grammar and literary usage – thus the historical application.

a. **KEY:** The Bible is unlike any other book of religious writings in that it is primarily a book of **HISTORY** and its history is ***true***. Our God has chosen to work within the framework of time and space. It is important to note that the Bible has **NEVER** been proven to be ***historically*** incorrect. Mark it down – rest assured!

b. Every **PERSON**, **PLACE**, and **EVENT** is real. Everything we read actually took place *(or will take place)* and existed ***historically***, unless God tells us otherwise *(IE. parables or symbolism – example – "Hear the parable of the…")*

c. This historical application concerns: *Bible Characters (*people*)*
*Geography (*places*)*
*Chronology (*time*)*
*Experiences (*events*)*

KEY: You must **FIRST** understand the history of any given passage before you will properly comprehend other basic applications. If you misunderstand the history, you will violate the obvious and literal meaning of scripture.

2) **DOCTRINAL**

a. The word doctrine simply means "*teaching."* In every thing that God says, He is always interested in teaching us something.

b. The biblical usages of the word doctrine (it has a two-fold meaning or usage):

- God uses historical events to teach a general practical truth. This is also called the **PLAIN** teaching

- God uses historical events to teach a deeper truth. This is also called the **PROPHETIC** teaching.

KEY: God establishes His eternal truths through sound doctrine that always stands sure throughout the entire Bible.

3) **DEVOTIONAL**

a. This "*old"* book applies to my life today. Every book, chapter, and verse **APPLIES** to me right now, somehow. The question we must always ask is this,

"*How must I apply what the Bible says to my personal life?"*

b. All scripture has a ***devotional*** application - *2 Timothy 3:16-17* – memorize it!

Note: *This factor is also referred to as* personal *or* **INSPIRATIONAL** *application.*

God's purpose in Scripture – watch how this is defined in Scripture…1 Corinthians 10:1-12; Romans 15:4; Luke 24:27; *John 5:39; 46-47*



The Bible is a **PICTURE** Book.

…to see the pictures best you must put on your "**3**-*D Glasses."*

Some examples:

a. The Brasen Serpent *(Numbers 21:4-9)*

i. ***History*** – this is a true story – it really happened
ii. ***Doctrine*** – The **plain** meaning in the time was that any and all bitten by the serpents needed to look at the brazen serpent for healing. **Prophetically**, it pointed to the cross of Christ – 2 Cor. 5:21; Jn. 3:14-15
iii. ***Devotion*** – there is always a price to pay when you don't believe God…

b. Isaiah's Sign of Immanuel (Isaiah 7:14-16)

i. ***History*** – a child born in Isaiah's day served as a sign to Ahaz that Syria and Israel would soon be defeated
ii. ***Doctrine*** – In the day, the **plain** teaching was that a child would be born as a sign of their victory in battle. The **PARTIAL FULFILLMENT** pointed forward **prophetically** to the complete fulfillment in the virgin birth of Jesus Christ, "God with us" – Matthew 1:18-23
iii. ***Devotion*** – God keeps his promises, remains with his people, and can be trusted even when circumstances appear hopeless!

c. Leviathan (Job 41)

i. ***History*** – God describes an actual historical animal in **hyperbole** (poetic section of books, uses much figure of speech), in order to show Job the true source of his troubles since ch. 1.
ii. ***Doctrine*** – Job is facing a foe that is so awful, so strong, so wicked, that he would have understood as an actual animal in his day. God used the animal to give Job the picture. But he also gave **prophetic/deeper** language that Job would have known (as we do today) cannot apply to ANY regular animal. It was **prophetically** showing Job a description of the devil.
iii. ***Devotion*** – how to deal with trials, suffering and attacks from the devil!

d. This is **not** an exhaustive list. Remember "all" of the OT pictured Jesus and NT truths for us.
i. The Strange Woman of Proverbs (Proverbs 5:3-7; 6:20-24; 7:1-5; Revelation 17:1-6); Abraham Offering Isaac (Genesis 22:1-14; Hebrews 11:17-19); The Passover Lamb (Exodus 12:1-13; John 1:29; 1 Corinthians 5:7); Noah and the Flood (Genesis 6-8; Matthew 24:37-39); Jonah and the Great Fish (Jonah 1:17-2:10; Matthew 12:39-41); The Manna from Heaven (Exodus 16:4-18; John 6:32-35); Water from the Rock (Exodus 17:1-6; 1 Corinthians 10:4); Adam as a Picture of Christ (Genesis 3; Romans 5:12-19; 1 Corinthians 15:45-49)

**** WARNING ****
This Bible study factor is not to be confused with the **ABSTRACT** method of Bible study developed by the epitome of all false teachers, *Adamantius Origen*. He developed what is known as the "*Allegorical method of Bible Study"...*

It is a method of reasoning that draws everything down to a metaphorical, figurative, or symbolic perspective. The danger, when applied as a method of Bible study, is that any passage is subject to the feelings or personal perspectives of the reader. This leaves the passage open for assorted types of interpretation that likely have nothing to do with what God is actually imparting. Who cares what someone thinks it means…what does it **SAY**! Be careful of Bible studies that go…read a verse then say," What do you think it means?"

KEY: The Bible says what it means, and means what it says. Anytime we apply the three basic applications to scripture, we must allow the biblical **TEXTS** to dictate the clear meaning.

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b. Every _____, _____, and _____ is real. Everything we read actually took place *(or will take place)* and existed ***historically***, unless God tells us otherwise *(IE. parables or symbolism – example – "Hear the parable of the…")*

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3) _____

a. This "*old"* book applies to my life today. Every book, chapter, and verse _____to me right now, somehow. The question we must always ask is this,

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KEY: The Bible says what it means, and means what it says. Anytime we apply the three basic applications to scripture, we must allow the biblical texts to dictate the clear meaning.

Addendum 3

Deuteronomy 4:2

Ye shall **not add unto the word** which I command you, neither shall ye diminish ought from it, that ye may keep the commandments of the LORD your God which I command you.

Deuteronomy 6:6

And **these words**, which I command thee this day, shall be in thine heart:

Deuteronomy 8:3

And he humbled thee, and suffered thee to hunger, and fed thee with manna, which thou knewest not, neither did thy fathers know; that he might make thee know that man doth not live by bread only, but **by every word** that proceedeth out of the mouth of the LORD doth man live.

Psalm 12:6-7

The **words** of the LORD are **pure words**: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever.

Psalm 119:89

For ever, O LORD, **thy word** is settled in heaven.

Psalm 119:160

Thy word is true from the beginning: and **every one of thy righteous judgments** endureth for ever.

Proverbs 30:5-6

Every word of God is pure: he is a shield unto them that put their trust in him. **Add thou not unto his words**, lest he reprove thee, and thou be found a liar.

Jeremiah 26:2

Thus saith the LORD; Stand in the court of the LORD'S house, and speak unto all the cities of Judah, which come to worship in the LORD'S house, **all the words** that I command thee to speak unto them; **diminish not a word**:

Matthew 4:4

But he answered and said, It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but **by every word** that proceedeth out of the mouth of God.

Matthew 5:18

For verily I say unto you, Till heaven and earth pass, **one jot** or **one tittle** shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled.

Matthew 24:35

Heaven and earth shall pass away, but **my words** shall not pass away.

Luke 16:17

And it is easier for heaven and earth to pass, than **one tittle** of the law to fail.

Revelation 22:18-19

For I testify unto every man that heareth **the words** of the prophecy of this book, If any man shall add unto these things, God shall add unto him the plagues that are written in this book: And if any man shall take away from **the words** of the book of this prophecy, God shall take away his part out of the book of life, and out of the holy city, and from the things which are written in this book.

#5 THE INDIVIDUAL WORD FACTOR

1. God has chosen every _____ and every individual _____ in the Bible for a specific purpose.

   a. John 20:30-31; 21:24-25

   KEY: If there was a multitude of other things Jesus said and did events), we must ***have the most important*** things preserved for us in the Bible!!

   b. Every word of God is ***key*** as opposed to man's interpretation of God's intended thoughts, message, concepts and ideals. (Deut. 4:2; Deut. 6:6; Deut. 8:3; Ps. 12:6-7; Ps. 119:89, 160; Prov. 30:5-6; Jer. 26:2; Matt. 4:4; Matt. 5:18; Matt. 24:35; Luke 16:17; Rev. 22:18-19)

   KEY: The key to the word of God, is the _____ _____ _____
   KEY: This is why God does not want us to _____, subtract, or _____ His perfect word!!

2. It is the _____ that are most important! The Bible does not just contain the words of God; the Bible is the pure word of God that will last forever (all of it…cover to cover)! – Psalm 12:6-7

   NOTE: This is in direct opposition to a belief system called Neo-Orthodoxy within theological circles which says that the ***thoughts*** are what really count! These so-called scholars proclaim that it does not matter what God actually said as long as we get the main point…be careful when you hear that!

   These men by their own admission, do NOT use the Bible as their authority for translating, studying, or handling the Bible. They rely upon textual sciences, human philosophies, and NOT THE BIBLE

   * Remember – God did not write a Bible for just anyone to understand – but only for those who are indwelt by His Spirit. Not all Bible "scholars" even claim to be believers!

   a. Matthew 5:18

   Psalm 119 is what is known as an ***acrostic*** psalm. There are 22 Hebrew letters in the Hebrew alphabet. Each stanza in Psalm 119 begins with a letter from the Hebrew alphabet.

   "Jot" – Psalm 119:73

   "Tittle" – Psalm 119:25 & 153

   b. In modern Bible versions, precise words are ***admittedly*** abandoned for the flow of thoughts and concepts for readability's sake. Words are replaced/changed without thought of preservation. This is known in textual criticism as "***dynamic equivalence***"

      i. ***Leland Ryken (PhD) professor of English at Wheaton College***: "Dynamic equivalence is popularly known as a thought-for-thought translation instead of a word-for-word translation."[1]

3. **KEY:** God preserved every word in English in the King James Bible – exactly the way He intended …

   Some Examples:

   - ✓ Hebrews 4:8; Acts 7:45 "Jesus" vs. "Joshua"
     - This is a "***transliteration***" that when translated exactly, word for word, teaches us a deep (doctrinal) truth of the Old Testament!

[1] Leland Ryken, *Choosing a Bible: Understanding Bible Translation Differences* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway Books, 2005), 7.

NOTICE: Just **_____** word makes a **BIG** difference!!!

- ✓ John 1:1 "**_____**" (many bible translations add this word; JW's infamously)
- ✓ John 7:8 "**yet**" (many bible translations remove this word)
- ✓ Acts 12:4 "**_____**" (many bible translations change this word to "Passover")
- ✓ 2 Timothy 2:15 "**dividing**" (changed to "handling" or "teaching" in many versions)
- ✓ 1 Cor. 1:18 "**being**" (many bible translations add this word")
- ✓ Genesis 3:4 (Gen. 2:14) "**_____**" (the original update to God's word: "thou shalt surely die."
- ✓ *This is NOT an exhaustive list of all examples. There are countless examples where every word added, subtracted, or changed makes a difference when studying the Bible. It is inevitable that when words are not the same, meanings change; hence God's warnings.*

4. God uses key words and phrases

- ✓ God uses key words and phrases in the Bible consistently to communicate truth…
- ✓ They establish contexts and provide ***keys*** for comparing scripture with scripture

Some examples:

- That day; The day; the day of the **_____** …begins with Rapture and ends with close of Millennium
- **_____** days; woman in travail; time of Jacob's Trouble…all references to the Tribulation Period
- **_____** and **_____** (similes) are key words God uses to demonstrate deeper understanding of something
  - ✓ Luke 17:26-30
  - ✓ 1 John 3:2 - *Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be* **like** *him; for we shall see him* **as** *he is.*
  - ✓ Eph. 5:25 - *Husbands, love your wives, even* ***as*** *Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it*
  - ✓ Matthew 10:16
- **_____** */* **_____** **VS.** **_____** */* **_____;** "ye" in the Bible is plural while "thee/thou" are singular (ex. Luke 22:31-32)
- Law of First Mention; the Bible study principle that the first time God uses a word, he defines it and establishes its meaning for the rest of scripture. If words are changed throughout to get the "ideas/thoughts", then this definition is easily lost (ex. "lovest" in Gen. 22:2; "worship" in Gen. 22:5)

FINAL THOUGHTS

- If we will approach the Bible with the attitude that **every word** is important, that **every word** is in place on purpose, and that **every word** is in fact the word of God…

  …it will change **what we see** and **what we _____**!!

- 1 Thessalonians 2:13 – *For this cause also thank we God without ceasing, because,* ***when ye received the word of God*** *which ye heard of us, ye received it not as the word of men, but as it is in truth,* ***the word of God****, which* ***effectually worketh*** *also in you that believe.*

#5 THE INDIVIDUAL WORD FACTOR

1. God has chosen every **EVENT** and every individual **WORD** in the Bible for a specific purpose.

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- ✓ 1 Cor. 1:18 "**being**" (many bible translations add this word")
- ✓ Genesis 3:4 "**not**" (the original update to God's word: "thou shalt surely die." (Gen. 2:14)
- ✓ *This is NOT an exhaustive list of all examples. There are countless examples where every word added, subtracted, or changed makes a difference when studying the Bible. It is inevitable that when words are not the same, meanings change; hence God's warnings.*

4. God uses key words and phrases

- ✓ God uses key words and phrases in the Bible consistently to communicate truth…
- ✓ They establish contexts and provide ***keys*** for comparing scripture with scripture

Some examples:

- That day; The day; the day of the **LORD** …begins with Rapture and ends with close of Millennium
- **THOSE** days; woman in travail; time of Jacob's Trouble…all references to the Tribulation Period
- **LIKE** and **AS** (similes) are key words God uses to demonstrate deeper understanding of something
  - ✓ Luke 17:26-30
  - ✓ 1 John 3:2 - *Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be* **like** *him; for we shall see him* **as** *he is.*
  - ✓ Eph. 5:25 - *Husbands, love your wives, even* ***as*** *Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it*
  - ✓ Matthew 10:16
- **YE/YOU VS. THEE/THOU;** "ye" in the Bible is plural while "thee/thou" are singular (ex. Luke 22:31-32)
- Law of First Mention; the Bible study principle that the first time God uses a word, he defines it and establishes its meaning for the rest of scripture. If words are changed throughout to get the "ideas/thoughts", then this definition is easily lost (ex. "lovest" in Gen. 22:2; "worship" in Gen. 22:5)

FINAL THOUGHTS

- If we will approach the Bible with the attitude that **every word** is important, that **every word** is in place on purpose, and that **every word** is in fact the word of God…

  …it will change **what we see** and **what we UNDERSTAND**!!

- 1 Thessalonians 2:13 – *For this cause also thank we God without ceasing, because,* ***when ye received the word of God*** *which ye heard of us, ye received it not as the word of men, but as it is in truth,* ***the word of God****, which* ***effectually worketh*** *also in you that believe.*

#6 THE COMPARISON FACTOR

1. The Bible is of no _____ interpretation. All interpretations must be done by comparing _____ with _____.

   a. No private interpretations – 2 Peter 1:20

      NOTE: Verse 20 clearly teaches us that the Bible is of ***no private interpretation***!

      - Whether we like it or not…
      - No matter what anybody else says…

      KEY: In a literal sense, this destroys the argument of all those who **hide behind** the saying…

      …"Well, that's just **your** interpretation."

      At issue is not your interpretation or mine, but rather **the interpretation of the Author** of the Bible – the _____ _____.

      Example – Who would be the best person to interpret a letter from me to you? _____

   b. Proper interpretation comes by comparing **spiritual** things with **spiritual** things– 1 Corinthians 2:1-14

      - Vs 1-8 Paul explains the contrast between man's wisdom and God's wisdom as revealed in His word
      - Vs 9-12 Even the "*deep things of God"* are revealed to those who possess His Spirit.
      - Vs 13 Comparing spiritual things with spiritual things is how the Holy Spirit teaches us.
      - Vs 14 The Word of God cannot be understood by mere human reasoning alone.

      NOTE: This is why the Bible is not meant to be read in the common "lingo" of any given day/age. It is meant to record God's exact words, that we are meant to study. The truth of the Bible is spiritually discerned as we _____ scripture with scripture (Romans 7:14; John 6:63). And this is only done effectively through the use of the exact words that God says.

      KEY: There comes a time in **serious study of the Bible**, to rightly divide the Scripture and pay due diligence to **every word**. That is the time to make certain you have a Bible that is not going to be dropping "jots" or "tittles" and removing the road signs and **landmarks!**

   c. God emphasizes the importance of two or three witnesses.

      NOTE: Having more than one witness/testimony to determine an unknown difficulty was established long ago by God! (2 Corinthians 13:1; Deuteronomy 19:15; Numbers 35:30)

   d. How cross referencing works – Isaiah 28:9-10, 13

      KEY: The best commentary on the Bible is the _____ itself, not our personal opinions.

      - To become proficient at understanding the Bible, we _____ exercise ourselves in the use of cross-referencing (e.g. – *study to shew thyself approved unto God*); tracking words and phrases throughout the Bible through the use of a **concordance** (hardback, online, on phone, etc.), through tools such as ***Treasury of Scripture Knowledge*** (hardback, online, on phone, etc.)***,*** and by **taking notes**.

- With today's technology, we have more capabilities at our fingertips than any other people throughout the course of human history!

- Remember, studying in this manner (comparing scripture with scripture) is how we're told to understand exactly what God is communicating to us…

- This is how we avoid our own personal opinions and private interpretations…

- Don't miss this critical _____ of Bible study…The Bible is of no private interpretation. All interpretations must be done by comparing scripture with scripture.

- Jesus, Paul, and the NT writers modeled use of this rule of Bible study when they would say _____ _____ _____

2. An illustration of this Bible study factor:

a. **Revelation 4:1-4**

What is this event? What is going on? **When we get context of the book, study every word, and compare scripture with scripture: we don't have to guess!**

What does the Bible say? …let's compare scripture with scripture…

- **1 Corinthians 15:51–54**
  The Lord calls, a trumpet sounds, and in a single moment, someone is raised in a spiritual body
- **1 Thessalonians 4:13–18**
  A voice yells, a trumpet sounds, and immediately we are "caught up" to be in the presense of the Lord forever!
  - These all describe _____ _____ The book of Revelation is the only definitive place in the New Testament that gives us the timeline of the rapture.

b. **Genesis 3:1-15**

NOTE: The devil tries to hide his identity all over the Bible, but we can identify him!

- **Revelation 12:9**
  He is called a dragon, that old serpent, the Devil, Satan.

- **Revelation 20:2**
  He is called a dragon, that old serpent, the Devil, Satan…AGAIN!

b. _____

- **Hipocrisy** (Luke 12:1)
- **Bad/False Doctrine** (Matt. 16:6, 11-12)
- **Negative** (Exod. 12:15–20; 13:3–7; 23:18; 34:25; Lev. 2:11; 6:17; 10:12; Deut. 16:3–4; Amos 4:5; Matt. 16:6, 11–12; Mark 8:15; Luke 12:1; 1 Cor. 5:6–8; Gal. 5:7–9)

We must remember…

- The Bible is of _____ private interpretation.

- _____ interpretations must be done by comparing scripture with scripture.

#6 THE COMPARISON FACTOR

1. The Bible is of no **PRIVATE** interpretation. All interpretations must be done by comparing **SCRIPTURE** with **SCRIPTURE**.

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      …"Well, that's just **your** interpretation."

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      Example – Who would be the best person to interpret a letter from me to you? **ME (AUTHOR)**

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      KEY: The best commentary on the Bible is the **BIBLE** itself, not our personal opinions.

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We must remember…

- The Bible is of **NO** private interpretation.

- **ALL** interpretations must be done by comparing scripture with scripture.

#7 THE CREATION FACTOR

1. The eternal truths of God that are revealed in the Bible can be enhanced by studying the _____ which He has made. God is a master artist!

   - Psalm 19:1-4a The Bible clearly says the heavens declare His righteousness.

     NOTE: God says His creation **declares**, **sheweth**, **uttereth** His righteousness…creation has a **voice**, **speech**, and a **line** of communication so unique that **all** people of **all** languages in _____ time periods of earth's history can hear it – see also Psalm 97:6, Job 12:7-9.

   - Romans 1:18-20 The invisible things of God are understood by _____ the creation He has made.

     NOTE: Creation is referred to as God's _____ REVELATION of Himself because anybody anywhere **can** see Him in it (Rom. 1:20). According to God, nobody can **honestly** give excuse that they did not know the truth about God (2 Pet. 3:3-5…because of the testimony of creation, God calls them willingly ignorant). **The Bible** is God's _____ REVELATION because it is written to those who **want** to know more about the God that they see in Creation and what His great plan is for man. The Bible and creation work hand-in-hand together proclaiming the truths of God.

     According to Romans 1:20…

     a. No one has an excuse because of:

        1. **GENERAL** revelation — It is general because creation is observable by everyone

        2. **SPECIAL** revelation — The Bible – God is always faithful to send a missionary

        NOTE: The "pigmy" or the lost multitudes in India, etc. are all included in this category…

     b. We also find that creation reveals an attribute of God called omnipotence (*omni* = all, *potent* = powerful):

        1. Examples of God's power seen in creation – _____
        2. Examples of God's eternal power seen in creation – _____

     c. God had a pattern when He created everything...the pattern was _____.

        The Godhead = the trinity = 3 (Father, Son, Holy Spirit)

        NOTE: He is the pattern! (see below)

2. **Examples of the Godhead that CAN be seen in creation:**
   - ✓ An atom (smallest matter known) is made up of protons, neutrons, and electrons.
   - ✓ A human being is made of 3 parts according to the Bible: _____, soul, and spirit – see Gen. 1:26-27.
   - ✓ Time is either past, present, or future. It also breaks down to years, months, and days. Each day has hours, minutes, and seconds. Every day has a morning, afternoon, and night.
   - ✓ Color breaks down to 3 primary colors: red, blue, and yellow.
   - ✓ The common states of matter are solid, liquid, or gas form.
   - ✓ Space equals height, width, and depth.
   - ✓ Reality has space, matter, and _____ associated with it.
   - ✓ Electrical charge is either positive, negative, or neutral.
   - ✓ Water (a basic compound) has 3 parts = H20 (2 hydrogen atoms, 1 oxygen).

- ✓ To make fire you need heat, fuel, and oxygen.
- ✓ There are 3 heavens according to the Bible: earth's atmosphere, outer space, and the 3rd heaven.
- ✓ Skin has a dermis, epidermis, and hypodermis.
- ✓ Teeth are made of the crown, neck/cervix, and root.
- ✓ A family consists of mother, father, and child(ren).
- ✓ There are 3 types of levers.
- ✓ There are 3 laws of _____.
- ✓ There are 3 dimensions to space/objects.
- ✓ A triangle is the strongest shape in creation.
- ✓ There are 3 God-ordained institutions: family, government, and the church.

3. **Examples of Bible principles/teachings that CAN be enhanced by observing/studying creation:**
   - ✓ **Wind** - John 3:8, Acts 2:2-4 = _____
   - ✓ **Trees** - Psalm 1:1-3, Mark 8:24 = _____
   - ✓ **Grass** - Isaiah 40:7,1 Peter 1:24 = _____
   - ✓ **Fog/Fog Breath**- James 4:14
   - ✓ **Clouds** - Matthew 26:64, Acts 1:11, 1 Thessalonians 4:17, Revelation 1:7
   - ✓ **Night** - Romans 13:1-11, 1 Thessalonians 5:2-5
   - ✓ **Rain** - Isaiah 55:10, Jeremiah 5:24
   - ✓ **Snow** - Isaiah 1:18, Mark 9:3, Revelation 1:14
   - ✓ **The Sun** - Malachi 4:2, Psalm 84:11, John 8:12
   - ✓ **Moon** - Job 25:5, Isaiah 60:1-3, Psalm 136:9
   - ✓ **Stars** - Revelation 1:20, 12:3-4
   - ✓ **Ants** - Proverbs 6:6-9, 30:25
   - ✓ **Fish** – Matthew 4:19, 17:24-27
   - ✓ **Deer** (Hart) - Psalm 42:1, Song 2:9, 17
   - ✓ **Rabbits** (Conies) - Psalm 104:18, Proverbs 30:26
   - ✓ **Rocks** - Psalm 18:2,46; 28:1; 31:3; 42:9; 62:2,6; 71:3; 92:15
   - ✓ **Gardens** - Matthew 13:18-23, Mark 4:14-20

KEY: After looking at some of the examples above, we are reminded of two very important words that will link the Bible to these examples in creation:

"_____" and "_____"

Why is this a Factor in Bible Study?: Rule #7 shows us that God uses the things that He made in creation to give us further evidence of the Bible. It is also important to use creation in witnessing because it is part of God's "general revelation" **seen by everybody, everyday**…there's no excuse…creation speaks to the lost and saved!!

#8 THE APPARENT CONTRADICTION FACTOR

1. There are _____ contradictions in the Bible, only "apparent contradictions." Always give God and the Bible the benefit of the doubt. To say that there is an error or discrepancy in your Bible and then move on like it is no big deal is heresy in light of Ps. 12:6-7, Pr. 30:5, etc.

   FIRST Understand that this important conclusion is first reached by _____ …believing that God's word is divinely inspired and without error. To those who believe, God will confirm His truth by demonstrating that there are _____ genuine contradictions that cannot be resolved.

   NEXT Although our conclusion for this factor is reached by faith, let us be reminded that genuine faith always has substance and evidence - Hebrews 11:1.

   THEN Consider that God's use of over _____ different authors to pen the Bible over 2,000 years in different cultures, time periods, etc. is going to bring some differences in style and the way events are recorded.

   FINALLY Whenever you find an "apparent" contradiction, immediately apply the rules of Bible study that you know to draw the _____ conclusion.

2. There are _____ for "apparent" contradictions in the Bible.

   - To give skeptics a lie to believe.

     Ezekiel 14:1-4, 9
     Isaiah 29:9-14
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     NOTE If you come to God with your own pre-conceived ideas, not at all sincerely interested in what God says (wanting to appear religious, etc.)…God will give you a lie to believe! This is not because God is a liar! It is because you were not willing to _____ Him, but rather your own lie! Most Christians miss this…in counseling…they believe the world's ways instead of God's ways. Why? It appeals to and satisfies the flesh! (Isaiah 30:1-3)

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3. Regarding the skeptics…

   - You will see/hear this accusation against the Bible often. Nine times out of ten when someone tells you there are contradictions in the Bible, they cannot show you one. So, ask them to show you one to prove it ... this will usually make them quiet on this accusation!

   - However, there is that tenth person…so let's look at a few "apparent contradictions" in the Bible…

4. Examples of some "apparent" contradictions:

a. **Proverbs 26:4-5** – Do you answer a fool according to his folly or not? How would you biblically figure that out?

b. **Exodus 20:13** (also Deut. 5:17)
Exodus 21:12-19 (*aka…thou shalt kill*)

Which is right? Do we have the right to kill or not?

Is this a contradiction in Chapters right next to each other, or is God empowering government?

See also Romans 13:1-4 in the New Testament!

c. **Mark 15:25** – According to this passage, Jesus was crucified in the **3rd** hour of the day.
John 19:14 – According to this passage, Pilate presented Jesus to the Jews who said "crucify him" in the **6th** hour of the day…and He was then crucified (that same day!)…Uh, oh.

You indeed need some deeper **study** to clear up this "apparent" contradiction!

The gospel of Mark is recorded using _____ time.

The Jewish day begins at 6:00 AM which places the crucifixion at 9:00 AM, which is the **3rd** hour of the **Jewish day.**

The gospel of John is recorded using _____ time.

The Roman day begins at 12:00 AM *(like ours does today)*. This places the trial of Christ by Pilate at 6:00 AM, which is the **6th** hour of the **Roman day**.

This time schedule works out perfectly (from different perspectives…Jewish/Gentile) and lines up perfectly as an accurate, detailed record of scripture.

It clearly demonstrates our factor tonight…that there are _____ contradictions in the Bible…

…only ***apparent*** contradictions.

Key Points

- ✓ Have a right heart attitude toward God and the Bible.
- ✓ Always approach the Bible by giving it the _____ of the doubt.
- ✓ Every apparent contradiction has a _____, even though you may not be mature enough or gifted enough just yet to find it.

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  1. Examples of God's power seen in creation – **TORNADOES, HURRICANES, TSUNAMIS**
  2. Examples of God's eternal power seen in creation – **STARS, SAND, GALAXIES**

  c. God had a pattern when He created everything...the pattern was **HIMSELF**.

  The Godhead = the trinity = 3 (Father, Son, Holy Spirit)

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   FINALLY Whenever you find an "apparent" contradiction, immediately apply the rules of Bible study that you know to draw the **RIGHT** conclusion.

2. There are **PURPOSES** for "apparent" contradictions in the Bible.

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     NOTE If you come to God with your own pre-conceived ideas, not at all sincerely interested in what God says (wanting to appear religious, etc.)…God will give you a lie to believe! This is not because God is a liar! It is because you were not willing to **BELIEVE** Him, but rather your own lie! Most Christians miss this…in counseling…they believe the world's ways instead of God's ways. Why? It appeals to and satisfies the flesh! (Isaiah 30:1-3)

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     John 6 – Jesus teaches the disciples words that seem to contradict (John 6:53; Gen. 9:4; Lev. 17:10-11; Duet. 12:23) The **SKEPTICS** walk away, while the believers stay (even though they don't fully understand yet; Jn. 6:67-69). Only once they had done this, were they then later allowed to understand the full truth of the story (Mt. 26:26-28; Mark 14:22-24; Luke 22:19-20; 1 Corinthians 11:23-26)

3. Regarding the skeptics…

   - You will see/hear this accusation against the Bible often. Nine times out of ten when someone tells you there are contradictions in the Bible, they cannot show you one. So, ask them to show you one to prove it ... this will usually make them quiet on this accusation!

   - However, there is that tenth person…so let's look at a few "apparent contradictions" in the Bible…

4. Examples of some "apparent" contradictions:

a. **Proverbs 26:4-5** – Do you answer a fool according to his folly or not? How would you biblically figure that out?

b. **Exodus 20:13** (also Deut. 5:17)
Exodus 21:12-19 (*aka…thou shalt kill*)

Which is right? Do we have the right to kill or not?

Is this a contradiction in Chapters right next to each other, or is God empowering government?

See also Romans 13:1-4 in the New Testament!

c. **Mark 15:25** – According to this passage, Jesus was crucified in the **3rd** hour of the day.
John 19:14 – According to this passage, Pilate presented Jesus to the Jews who said "crucify him" in the **6th** hour of the day…and He was then crucified (that same day!)…Uh, oh.

You indeed need some deeper **study** to clear up this "apparent" contradiction!

The gospel of Mark is recorded using **JEWISH** time.

The Jewish day begins at 6:00 AM which places the crucifixion at 9:00 AM, which is the **3rd** hour of the **Jewish day.**

The gospel of John is recorded using **ROMAN** time.

The Roman day begins at 12:00 AM *(like ours does today)*. This places the trial of Christ by Pilate at 6:00 AM, which is the **6th** hour of the **Roman day**.

This time schedule works out perfectly (from different perspectives…Jewish/Gentile) and lines up perfectly as an accurate, detailed record of scripture.

It clearly demonstrates our factor tonight…that there are **NO** contradictions in the Bible…

…only ***apparent*** contradictions.

Key Points

- ✓ Have a right heart attitude toward God and the Bible.
- ✓ Always approach the Bible by giving it the **BENEFIT** of the doubt.
- ✓ Every apparent contradiction has a **SOLUTION**, even though you may not be mature enough or gifted enough just yet to find it.

#9 THE CONSISTENCY FACTOR

1. When studying the Bible, we must pay attention to the _____ of God.

   - There is a consistency to layout, words, and principles of the _____ …because there is a consistent nature to our God!

     Col. 1:17 The laws and order we find in creation are consistent because of Jesus Christ. (Newton's laws of motion, Laws of Thermodynamics, gravity's pull, how atoms work, etc.)

     Heb.13:8 *Jesus Christ the same yesterday, and to day, and for ever*. (He is the Word!)

     James 1:17 *…from the Father of lights, with whom is no variableness, neither shadow of turning.*

     Malachi 3:6 *For I am the LORD, I change not; therefore ye sons of Jacob are not consumed.*

   NOTE This does not contradict the fact that God does things differently at different times (the Time Period Factor). These are two distinctly different points.

2. God's consistency and the "Law of First Mention"

   - It is very common for the _____mention of something in the Bible to establish a truth or _____ that is ***consistently*** followed throughout the entire Bible. You will observe these truths and patterns illustrated in figures (*pictures*) and truth (*words*) ***throughout the scriptures***.

   - This Bible phenomenon has been nicknamed… "The _____ of First Mention."

   - Genesis is a key book for many *"First Mentions."* Here are a few examples:

     "The serpent and his attack" - Genesis 3:1-5 (first mention)
     - ✓ The serpent is consistently associated with sin and the devil (see also Rev. 12:9, 20:2).
     - ✓ The devil's main attack is always against God's _____(questions/contradicts/changes).
     - ✓ 2 Cor. 11:3 – *"But I fear…as the **serpent** beguiled Eve through his subtilty, **so** your minds should be corrupted from the simplicity that is in Christ."*
     - ✓ John 3:14 – *"…as Moses lifted up **the serpent** in the wilderness, **even so** must the Son of man be lifted up"* (see Numbers 21)

     "*Babel* or *Babylon*" - Genesis 10:10; 11:1-9 (first mention)
     - ✓ The first mention of Babel or Babylon involves false _____and is and will be just like the false religion that Antichrist will use to deceive during the tribulation period (Rev. 17:5).

     "*love*" - Genesis 22:2 (first mention)
     - ✓ The first mention of *love* in the Bible is associated with a loving father offering up his only son as a sacrifice. A New Testament word used as synonymously for love is _____**!**

     "*worship*" - Genesis 22:5 (first mention)
     - ✓ The first mention of *worship* involves a man being tested and trusting God to do the super-natural. True worship is associated with deep personal **sacrifice** and **faith** leading to a life changing encounter with God!

     "Egypt"- Genesis 12:10 (first mention)
     - ✓ "Egypt is mentioned some 600 times in the Bible and its first mention is significant. It is mentioned first in Genesis 12:10 when we read that Abraham, faced with a famine in the Promised Land, "went down into Egypt to sojourn there." Egypt, when used in the Bible, symbolizes the world: this world's system, human life, and society with God left out. In its

wealth and wisdom, its politics and religion, its culture and magnificence, this world is a snare to the believer."[2]

- When seeking understanding or clarification about an issue in the Bible, always check the 1st time the word or subject is mentioned. This factor is a great key, but it does not unlock every door.

NOTE. God's consistency and the "Law of Progressive Mention": First Mention introduces the subject; Progressive Mention follows the subject as God adds more revelation.

- The Lamb is a perfect example: Genesis 22 introduces God's provided lamb as a picture; Exodus 12 develops this idea of substitution and blood; Isaiah 53 reveals the Lamb as a suffering person; John 1:29 identifies Him as Jesus; Revelation 5 presents the slain Lamb risen and reigning.

3. God's consistency and His use of numbers in the Bible:

- **Three** - Romans 1:20, 1 John 5:7 (see also rule #7 study sheet)
  - ✓ Three is associated with the structure of the _____ and the trinity.
  - ✓ Three also has significance with resurrection and the new life associated with Jesus Christ (____day).
- **Four** – Isaiah 11:12
  - ✓ Four seems to associate with the _____
  - ✓ Mark 13:27 – *"And then shall he send his angels, and shall gather together his elect from the **four winds**, **from the uttermost part of the earth** to the uttermost part of heaven."*
- **Five** - Genesis 5:5 (first mention)
  - ✓ Five IS associated all over the Bible with death – death, grave, beast, grave, Satan, devil, _____
- **Six** - Revelation 13:18
  - ✓ God emphasizes this one! Six is the number of _____. Specifically, fallen man or man's incompleteness.
- **Seven** - Genesis 2:2-3 (first mention)
  - ✓ God finishes with creation and He rests on the _____day. Seven is emphasized throughout the Bible as God's number for _____.
- **Eight** - 2 Peter 2:5
  - ✓ Eight is the number representing new _____. (Seven is the number of completion!)
- **Nine** - Genesis 9:1, 9 (first mention) – Noah commissioned to bear fruit
  - ✓ Nine seems to be a number God uses related to _____.
- **Ten** - Genesis 10:10 (The first _____ kingdom)
  - ✓ Ten is a number that represents **Gentiles**, or non-Jews.
- **Twelve** - Genesis 12
  - ✓ Twelve is the number associated with the nation of _____ and Jews.
- **Thirteen** – Genesis 14:4 (first mention)
  - ✓ Thirteen is associated with_____
  - ✓ "Number THIRTEEN is the number of rebellion and apostasy. Its first occurrence is in Genesis 14:4 – "'Twelve years they served Chedorlaomer, and in the thirteenth year they rebelled." In this verse, thirteen appears and proves rebellion and government resisted. Beginning at this point, and appearing throughout Scripture, thirteen suggests rebellion, sin, and disobedience."[3]
- **Forty** – Genesis 7:4 (first mention)
  - ✓ Forty is related to a time of being tested or _____.

CONCLUSION

We must look for and apply the _____ patterns God has established throughout the Bible as we study it. God is very consistent with His words, principles, and even how He uses numbers. Also, when seeking understanding or clarification on an issue in the Bible, always check the **first time** the word or subject is **mentioned**.

[2] John Phillips, *Bible Explorer's Guide: How to Understand and Interpret the Bible* (Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel Publications, 2002), 127.

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  - ✓ Mark 13:27 – *"And then shall he send his angels, and shall gather together his elect from the **four winds**, **from the uttermost part of the earth** to the uttermost part of heaven."*
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- **Six** - Revelation 13:18
  - ✓ God emphasizes this one! Six is the number of **MAN**. Specifically, fallen man or man's incompleteness.
- **Seven** - Genesis 2:2-3 (first mention)
  - ✓ God finishes with creation and He rests on the **7TH** day. Seven is emphasized throughout the Bible as God's number for **COMPLETION**.
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  - ✓ Eight is the number representing new **BEGINNINGS**. (Seven is the number of completion!)
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  - ✓ Nine seems to be a number God uses related to **FRUITFULNESS/FRUITBEARING**.
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  - ✓ Ten is a number that represents **Gentiles**, or non-Jews.
- **Twelve** - Genesis 12
  - ✓ Twelve is the number associated with the nation of **ISRAEL** and Jews.
- **Thirteen** – Genesis 14:4 (first mention)
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CONCLUSION

We must look for and apply the **CONSISTENT** patterns God has established throughout the Bible as we study it. God is very consistent with His words, principles, and even how He uses numbers. Also, when seeking understanding or clarification on an issue in the Bible, always check the **first time** the word or subject is **mentioned**.

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#10 THE LITERAL FACTOR

1. Always take a passage _____ until it is impossible to take it literally or if there is clear instruction from the scripture that we are dealing with _____.

   - This is commonly known in Biblical Studies as the "_____ _____" of Bible study. It is typically stated this way, "When the plain sense of Scripture makes common sense, seek no other sense."[4] [5] [6]
   - It is also important to remember that we can interpret the Bible literally, consistently only because of the foundational rules established earlier in this class. These principles cannot be ignored or passed over.

   NOTE Many will say something is "symbolic" in the scripture as opposed to taking it literally, exactly as it is written, as an excuse to justify lack of understanding.

   Matthew 13:1-23 _____ What is a parable? Verses 10-12; Jesus explains them!
   Revelation 1:12-20 _____
   Ezekiel 37:1-11 _____
   John 6:35, 53-63 _____

   KEY Very few passages in the Bible are symbolic. Symbolism that does exist is usually clearly defined in the immediate context. *(Those not defined in the context can be defined elsewhere in the Bible by comparing scripture with scripture. Ex. – Rev. 12:1-5)*

2. Keep in mind that God _____to us, through the words of the Bible, just like we talk: *(God records real life)*

   - **Figures of speech** - Gen. 4:10; Lev. 18:25; Nu. 14:9; Joshua 24:27; Prov. 18:2
     - *Figure of speech - Figuratively explaining something (IE. sunrise / sunset…Matt. 5:45; Mark 1:32)*
   - **Sarcasm** - Judges 9:7-15; 10:14; 1 Kings 18:27; Job 12:2-3; 18:5; 2 Co. 11:16-19; Acts 2:13
     - *Sarcasm - cutting or taunting in order to aggravate or hurt someone's feelings; a mocking remark utilizing statements opposite or irrelevant to the underlying meaning.*
   - **Hyperboles** - Gen. 33:10; Deut. 1:28; Judges 7:12; 2 Kings 19:24; Jer. 15:16; 1 Co. 13:1-2; 2 Co. 7:14
     - *Hyperbole - An exaggerated statement used for effect not meant to be taken literally.*
   - **Satire** - Isaiah 44:14-17; Gen. 37:19; 1 Samuel 17:41-44; Eccl. 2:1-11; Matthew 23:1-33
     - *Satire - A literary work in which irony, derision, or wit is used to expose folly or wickedness.*

KEY POINT **Always** take a passage **literally** unless it is impossible to do so!

This factor _____what you read and will increase your comprehension of the Bible!

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[4] Roy B. Zuck, *Basic Bible Interpretation: A Practical Guide to Discovering Biblical Truth* (Wheaton, IL: Victor Books, 1991), 146.
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[6] Charles C. Ryrie, *Dispensationalism*, rev. and expanded ed. (Chicago: Moody Press, 1995), 80.

#11 THE ATTITUDE FACTOR

1. Always be ready to _____whatever you have been taught or you have believed when you find it goes _____to the Bible – James 1:22-25.

   - John 3:1-18 _____can **blind us** from what we should believe.
   - Mark 7:1-13 _____can **bind us** to unbiblical beliefs.
   - John 11:23-27 – God will _____our beliefs.
   - Mark 10:17-26 – Sometimes we will choose not to believe. We know better.
   - Luke 6:46-49 – Our beliefs will determine the _____and steadfastness of our lives.
   - 2 Kings 22-23 – The example of good king Josiah and his crisis of belief.

   KEY #1 We must always line ourselves up to what the Bible **clearly** _____!

   KEY #2 We must be careful not to make the Bible say what we want it to say!

2. Our **personal beliefs** are formed by our upbringing, societal pressures/teaching, and personal experience. The following are a few examples of issues the Bible speaks about that may challenge your own personal beliefs and actions:

   - ✓ *Managing finances –*
   - ✓ *Dating –*
   - ✓ *Biblical relationships –*
   - ✓ *Marriage responsibilities –*
   - ✓ *Child rearing and discipline –*
   - ✓ *Proper use of alcohol –*
   - ✓ *Giving –*
   - ✓ *Church service schedules –*
   - ✓ *Attitudes/actions toward authority –*
   - ✓ *Work ethic –*

3. Have an _____attitude toward God when you come to a crisis of belief with His word.

   - Mark 9:23-24 –

   NOTE Changes in our beliefs will cause changes in our _____and attitudes.

   KEY Many people are not able to apply this factor of Bible study because they **do not** have a final authority. If you **do not** have a final authority, _____become the final authority.

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1. Always take a passage **LITERALLY** until it is impossible to take it literally or if there is clear instruction from the scripture that we are dealing with **SYMBOLISM**.

- This is commonly known in Biblical Studies as the "**GOLDEN RULE**" of Bible study. It is typically stated this way, "When the plain sense of Scripture makes common sense, seek no other sense."[4] [5] [6]
- It is also important to remember that we can interpret the Bible literally, consistently only because of the foundational rules established earlier in this class. These principles cannot be ignored or passed over.

NOTE Many will say something is "symbolic" in the scripture as opposed to taking it literally, exactly as it is written, as an excuse to justify lack of understanding.

Matthew 13:1-23 **PARABLES** What is a parable? Verses 10-12; Jesus explains them!
- Jesus then interprets the symbols in **verses 18-23**, showing that it was all clearly meant as symbolism/not literal/imagery

Revelation 1:12-20 **SYMBOLISM**

Ezekiel 37:1-11 **SYMBOLISM**
- Ezekiel sees a valley full of dry bones. As he prophesies, the bones come together, receive flesh and breath, and become a great living army. God explains that the bones symbolize the whole house of Israel, pictured as dead and hopeless but later restored by God.

John 6:35, 53-63 **SYMBOLISM**

KEY Very few passages in the Bible are symbolic. Symbolism that does exist is usually clearly defined in the immediate context. *(Those not defined in the context can be defined elsewhere in the Bible by comparing scripture with scripture. Ex. – Rev. 12:1-5)*

2. Keep in mind that God **TALKS** to us, through the words of the Bible, just like we talk: *(God records real life)*

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- **Sarcasm** - Judges 9:7-15; 10:14; 1 Kings 18:27; Job 12:2-3; 18:5; 2 Co. 11:16-19; Acts 2:13
  - Elijah clearly does not believe that they may have a god who is just sleeping or on a trip, he is mocking and using sarcasm. Job clearly does not believe his friends possess all wisdom and when they die, all wisdom will cease to exist (as evidenced by the context vs. 3)
  - *Sarcasm - cutting or taunting in order to aggravate or hurt someone's feelings; a mocking remark utilizing statements opposite or irrelevant to the underlying meaning.*
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  - *Satire - A literary work in which irony, derision, or wit is used to expose folly or wickedness.*
  - The events described are literal, but Isaiah presents them satirically to show the absurdity of worshipping something a man made with his own hands. The purpose is what we are to understand. He is not giving instruction on woodworking, but using this as a condemnation of making gods with mans own hands.

KEY POINT **Always** take a passage **literally** unless it is impossible to do so!

This factor **SIMPLIFIES** what you read and will increase your comprehension of the Bible!

#11 THE ATTITUDE FACTOR

1. Always be ready to **CHANGE** whatever you have been taught or you have believed when you find it goes **CONTRARY** to the Bible – James 1:22-25.

- John 3:1-18 **RELIGION** can **blind us** from what we should believe.
  - Nicodemus was so religious, so entrenched in his beliefs and religion, that he was unable to see clear and simple teaching that was right in front of him. He was so wound up he was thinking ridiculous things! Jesus speaks to him in one of the simplest and strongest statements of the Bible about salvation in Christ. **Are we so religious that we are unable to see clearly when God wants us to change what we believe, when confronted with his word?**

- Mark 7:1-13 **TRADITION** can **bind us** to unbiblical beliefs.
  - We can "worship" God in vain (empty, fake), when it is according to our traditions and not God's word. Worship is sacrifice and giving of ourselves to God completely. How sad is it that someone could waste their life, sacrificing it to God, all in vain, because it was based on tradition and not God's word. Many do it never knowing that they were doing it in vain.
  - How do we fix this? Ask the question: "Is what I am doing/sacrificing for BIBLICAL? Or, is it a tradition of men? If it is not Biblical, ask, "Why am I doing this? Who is telling me to do this? God or man/tradition?"

- John 11:23-27 – God will **CHALLENGE** our beliefs.
  - Jesus is speaking to Martha about the death of Lazarus and he tells her that "he is the resurrection and the life." There were many disagreements amongst the Pharisees and Saducees about the resurrection of the dead at this time in history. Martha was thinking in their terms, Jesus fixes it all and clarifies that HE IS THE RESSURECTION AND THE LIFE.

- Mark 10:17-26 – Sometimes we will choose not to believe. We know **BETTER**.
  - The issue in this story is an issue as old as time, and it is the basis of all sin in our lives and it is the killer of any fruit, any learning, and growth: PRIDE! The rich young man did not have a lack of knowledge of what to do; he clearly understood. He simply did not want to do it. Just as the Devil has no lack of knowledge of the power, glory, eternality, death, resurrection, etc.. of Christ; he simply will not bow his life to Him.
  - Many have no problem comprehending what the Bible teaches, it is written in plain English for our understanding. However, our issue as mankind, is our unwillingness to submit ourselves to God's word and his will for us.

- Luke 6:46-49 – Our beliefs will determine the **FOUNDATION** and steadfastness of our lives.
  - Those who hear and refuse to obey, their lives always are shaky, unbalanced, constantly collapsing, etc.. because they refuse to obey, even though they know what they are supposed to do. There is no harder life than this life as a runaway child of God (prodigal son).

- 2 Kings 22-23 – The example of good king Josiah and his **CRISIS** of belief.
  - Judah had drifted far from God and had been living contrary to His Word. While the temple was being repaired, Hilkiah the priest found "the book of the law in the house of the LORD" (2 Kings 22:8).
    When the book was read to Josiah, he realized how far the nation had departed from Scripture. "When the king had heard the words of the book of the law, that he rent his clothes" (22:11). He immediately recognized that Judah was doing things against God and his word: "Great is the wrath of the LORD... because our fathers have not hearkened unto the words of this book" (22:13).
    Josiah did not defend what they had always done or their "tradition". He gathered the people and "read in their ears all the words of the book of the covenant" (23:2). Then he "made a covenant before the LORD, to walk after the LORD, and to keep his commandments" (23:3).
    After that, Josiah began removing the idols, false worship, corrupt priests, and practices that contradicted God's Word. When Josiah discovered that what he and his nation had been doing was contrary to Scripture, he changed it.

KEY #1 We must always line ourselves up to what the Bible **clearly SAYS**!

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2. Our **personal beliefs** are formed by our upbringing, societal pressures/teaching, and personal experience. The following are a few examples of issues the Bible speaks about that may challenge your own personal beliefs and actions:

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- Mark 9:23-24 –

NOTE Changes in our beliefs will cause changes in our **ACTIONS** and attitudes.

KEY Many people are not able to apply this factor of Bible study because they **do not** have a final authority. If you **do not** have a final authority, **YOU** become the final authority.

#12 THE CLARITY FACTOR

1. Never violate a _____ passage when trying to understand an _____ (uncertain) passage.

    - There are obscure passages in the Bible – 2 Peter 3:16

    - Some passages are clearly _____ for now – Proverbs 25:2; Daniel 12:4, 8-9; Ephesians 3:1-7; 1 Pet. 1:6-12; John 16:12

    - A few examples:

    FAITH ALONE VS. WORKS

    Clear

    ✓ Ephesians 2:8-9; Titus 3:5; Rom. 10:9-10; John 3:16; Romans 4:5; Galatians 2:16; Romans 11:6; 2 Timothy 1:9

    Obscure

    ✓ James 2:24; Hebrews 3:6

    BAPTISM AS PART OF SALVATION PROCESS

    Clear

    ✓ John 3:16; Ephesians 2:8–9; Titus 3:5; Romans 4:5; Romans 10:9–10; Acts 16:30–31; 1 Corinthians 1:14–17; Acts 8:36–38; Luke 23:42–43

    Obscure

    ✓ 1 Peter 3:21; Acts 2:38

2. Key points to remember when you encounter an obscure passage:

    - There are always **many, many more** _____ passages about a subject than obscure ones!

    - Apply the rules of Bible study to find the clear meaning of any difficult passage. If you cannot get clarity on a verse or passage concerning the subject matter after applying the rules of Bible study, move on for now, give God the benefit of the doubt, and trust the clear verses/passages that you do understand.

    - Eventually, you will always find that whatever an obscure passage means will _____ conflict with other scripture taken in context. (Ps. 12:6-7; Pr. 30:5)

#13 THE QUESTION FACTOR

1. Never base a doctrine on a _____. Questions are designed to investigate, interrogate, and _____ an answer. Sometimes questions in the Bible can be rhetorical to support an answer, but remember, they are questions, NOT answers. This rule is strongly connected to the CLARITY FACTOR, yet they are distinct.

    "Obscure passages must always give way to clear passages. Further, we must never build a doctrine on obscure or difficult passages. Everything essential to salvation or to Christian living is clearly revealed in the Bible. We have no need to resort to obscure passages to support a Biblical belief. One such obscure passage in the Bible is found in 1 Corinthians 15:29, where we read: "Else what shall they do which are baptized for the dead, if the dead rise not at all? why are they then baptized for the dead?" The meaning of this passage is the subject of considerable controversy. The Mormons have formulated a doctrine of baptism for the dead based on this passage."[7]

[7] John Phillips, Bible Explorer's Guide: How to Understand and Interpret the Bible (Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel Publications, 2002), 108.

- Many strange and heretical doctrines are based on _____in the Bible, not clear teachings of God:

  - ✓ Extremist views of predestination (Calvinism) are based on a series of questions – *Rom. 9:13-24*

    While there are many passages used by Calvinists, their main areas used for doctrine are questions!

  - ✓ Heretical teachings concerning grace plus works are based on a series of questions – *Jam. 2:20-26*

    The James text poses a question…a question cannot be the foundation for something as significant as teaching the Christian's salvation and eternal life are based on grace + works.

  - ✓ The bizarre Mormon doctrine *,"baptism for the dead,"* is based on a single question in 1 Corinthians – *1 Cor. 15:29*

Key Point When a sole verse or passage is a question, it will _____ be the foundation for any significant Biblical doctrine. Therefore, ***never base a Bible doctrine on a question***.

#14 THE CONFIRMATION FACTOR

1. Never base a particular doctrine on _____verse or passage alone. God always bases Bible doctrine (His clear teachings) on more than one verse!

   - Anytime God establishes a significant foundational truth, He ***always*** confirms it in the mouth of two or three _____ –2 Cor. 13:1; *Deut. 19:15; Num. 35:30*; *Isa. 28:9-10, 13*

     - ✓ 1 Cor. 15:29 — As we have already seen, the strange doctrine of "*baptism for the dead"* is based on _____lone verse in the Bible (and a question at that!). Where else is baptism for the dead ever mentioned? Nowhere!

     - ✓ 1 Cor. 13:1 — Is there a heavenly language that angels speak? Or is this just a figure of speech? It is a figure of speech because when we compare scripture with scripture, we find that angels speak in _____!! When angels speak, people understand them!! What other verses support a heavenly angelic language?

     - ✓ Matt.16:18 — Does this verse establish that Peter was to be the first pope in Rome? **1.2 billion people** follow a leadership system based on this _____ single verse.
       - Peter is not presented as the Rock, Christ is (**1 Cor. 10:4; 1 Pet. 2:4–8; Eph. 2:20; Isa. 28:16**); Peter was married (**Matt. 8:14; Mark 1:30; 1 Cor. 9:5**); Peter called himself a "fellow elder," not the supreme ruler of the church (**1 Pet. 5:1–4**); Peter explicitly refused religious reverence from Cornelius (**Acts 10:25–26**); Peter was publicly rebuked and corrected by Paul when he was wrong (**Gal. 2:11–14**); Peter was not the final authority at the Jerusalem council. James gave the concluding judgment (**Acts 15:7–20**); Christ, not Peter, is repeatedly called the Head of the Church (**Eph. 1:22–23; 4:15; 5:23; Col. 1:18; 2:19**); The foundation of the church is not Peter alone, but the apostles and prophets, with Jesus Christ as the chief cornerstone (**Eph. 2:20; Rev. 21:14**); Paul wrote an entire epistle to the Christians at Rome and greeted many believers by name without mentioning Peter (**Rom. 16:1–16**); When Paul was imprisoned in Rome, he mentioned numerous fellow workers but never identified Peter as the head of the Roman church (**Col. 4:7–14; 2 Tim. 4:9–12, 16**).

   - Remember to always _____ scripture with scripture *(Factor #6)*.

Key Point If an unusual doctrine in a verse/passage is not found supported anywhere else in the Bible... leave it

#12 THE CLARITY FACTOR

1. Never violate a **CLEAR** passage when trying to understand an **OBSCURE** (uncertain) passage.

   - There are obscure passages in the Bible – 2 Peter 3:16
   - Some passages are clearly **CLOSED** for now – Proverbs 25:2; Daniel 12:4, 8-9; Ephesians 3:1-7; 1 Pet. 1:6-12; John 16:12
   - A few examples:

   FAITH ALONE VS. WORKS

   Clear

   ✓ Ephesians 2:8-9; Titus 3:5; Rom. 10:9-10; John 3:16; Romans 4:5; Galatians 2:16; Romans 11:6; 2 Timothy 1:9

   Obscure

   ✓ James 2:24; Hebrews 3:6

   BAPTISM AS PART OF SALVATION PROCESS

   Clear

   ✓ John 3:16; Ephesians 2:8–9; Titus 3:5; Romans 4:5; Romans 10:9–10; Acts 16:30–31; 1 Corinthians 1:14–17; Acts 8:36–38; Luke 23:42–43

   Obscure

   ✓ 1 Peter 3:21; Acts 2:38

2. Key points to remember when you encounter an obscure passage:

   - There are always **many, many more CLEAR** passages about a subject than obscure ones!
   - Apply the rules of Bible study to find the clear meaning of any difficult passage. If you cannot get clarity on a verse or passage concerning the subject matter after applying the rules of Bible study, move on for now, give God the benefit of the doubt, and trust the clear verses/passages that you do understand.
   - Eventually, you will always find that whatever an obscure passage means will **NEVER** conflict with other scripture taken in context. (Ps. 12:6-7; Pr. 30:5)

#13 THE QUESTION FACTOR

1. Never base a doctrine on a **QUESTION**. Questions are designed to investigate, interrogate, and **EXPOSE** an answer. Sometimes questions in the Bible can be rhetorical to support an answer, but remember, they are questions, NOT answers. This rule is strongly connected to the CLARITY FACTOR, yet they are distinct.

   "Obscure passages must always give way to clear passages. Further, we must never build a doctrine on obscure or difficult passages. Everything essential to salvation or to Christian living is clearly revealed in the Bible. We have no need to resort to obscure passages to support a Biblical belief. One such obscure passage in the Bible is found in 1 Corinthians 15:29, where we read: "Else what shall they do which are baptized for the dead, if the dead rise not at all? why are they then baptized for the dead?" The meaning of this passage is the subject of considerable controversy. The Mormons have formulated a doctrine of baptism for the dead based on this passage."[7]

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- Many strange and heretical doctrines are based on **QUESTIONS** in the Bible, not clear teachings of God:

  ✓ Extremist views of predestination (Calvinism) are based on a series of questions – *Rom. 9:13-24*

  While there are many passages used by Calvinists, their main areas used for doctrine are questions!

  ✓ Heretical teachings concerning grace plus works are based on a series of questions – *Jam. 2:20-26*

  The James text poses a question…a question cannot be the foundation for something as significant as teaching the Christian's salvation and eternal life are based on grace + works.

  ✓ The bizarre Mormon doctrine *,"baptism for the dead,"* is based on a single question in 1 Corinthians – *1 Cor. 15:29*

Key Point When a sole verse or passage is a question, it will **NOT** be the foundation for any significant Biblical doctrine. Therefore, ***never base a Bible doctrine on a question***.

#14 THE CONFIRMATION FACTOR

1. Never base a particular doctrine on **ONE** verse or passage alone. God always bases Bible doctrine (His clear teachings) on more than one verse!

   - Anytime God establishes a significant foundational truth, He ***always*** confirms it in the mouth of two or three **WITNESSES** –2 Cor. 13:1; *Deut. 19:15; Num. 35:30; Isa. 28:9-10, 13*

     ✓ 1 Cor. 15:29 — As we have already seen, the strange doctrine of "*baptism for the dead"* is based on **ONE** lone verse in the Bible (and a question at that!). Where else is baptism for the dead ever mentioned? Nowhere!

     - 1 Cor. 13:1 — Is there a heavenly language that angels speak? Or is this just a figure of speech? It is a figure of speech because when we compare scripture with scripture, we find that angels speak in **HEBREW**!! When angels speak, people understand them!! What other verses support a heavenly angelic language?

     - Matt.16:18 — Does this verse establish that Peter was to be the first pope in Rome? **1.2 billion people** follow a leadership system based on this **ONE** single verse.
       - Peter is not presented as the Rock, Christ is (**1 Cor. 10:4; 1 Pet. 2:4–8; Eph. 2:20; Isa. 28:16**); Peter was married (**Matt. 8:14; Mark 1:30; 1 Cor. 9:5**); Peter called himself a "fellow elder," not the supreme ruler of the church (**1 Pet. 5:1–4**); Peter explicitly refused religious reverence from Cornelius (**Acts 10:25–26**); Peter was publicly rebuked and corrected by Paul when he was wrong (**Gal. 2:11–14**); Peter was not the final authority at the Jerusalem council. James gave the concluding judgment (**Acts 15:7–20**); Christ, not Peter, is repeatedly called the Head of the Church (**Eph. 1:22–23; 4:15; 5:23; Col. 1:18; 2:19**); The foundation of the church is not Peter alone, but the apostles and prophets, with Jesus Christ as the chief cornerstone (**Eph. 2:20; Rev. 21:14**); Paul wrote an entire epistle to the Christians at Rome and greeted many believers by name without mentioning Peter (**Rom. 16:1–16**); When Paul was imprisoned in Rome, he mentioned numerous fellow workers but never identified Peter as the head of the Roman church (**Col. 4:7–14; 2 Tim. 4:9–12, 16**).

   - Remember to always **COMPARE** scripture with scripture *(Factor #6)*.

Key Point If an unusual doctrine in a verse/passage is not found supported anywhere else in the Bible... leave it alone.

#15 THE MATURITY FACTOR

1. God is infinitely wise. We will _____ completely understand God. We are on a **LIFE**-long mission to know God and understand/experience His ways more until the day we are physically glorified - Ex. 33:18-23; Phil. 3:9-17.

    - Isaiah 55:8-9 – If we could ever completely understand God, we would be His _____!

    - If you find something you don't understand, try your best to get it, being careful not to violate any of the rules of Bible study. If you still can't understand it, don't worry about it. God reveals His word to us in progression... ***as we are able to handle it***. We must also remember a humbling fact…God will not _____ us with more if we are not faithful with what we have now.

    KEY We must work to _____ what we ***do understand***, and then wait on God for more – Phil. 2:12-13

2. Always keep John 16:12 in your thinking… *"I have yet **many things** to say unto you, but ye cannot bear them now."*

15 Factors to Focus your Bible Study:

1. The Context Factor
2. The People Factor
3. The Division (time) Factor
4. The Application Factor
5. The Individual Word Factor
6. The Comparison Factor
7. The Creation Factor
8. The Apparent Contradiction Factor
9. The Consistency Factor
10. The Literal Factor
11. The Attitude Factor
12. The Clarity Factor
13. The Question Factor
14. The Confirmation Factor
15. The Maturity Factor

FINAL THOUGHTS

1. A Few More Key Principles to Store in your Toolbelt

    a. The Kingdom of Heaven Vs. The Kingdom of God
        i. "The Kingdom of Heaven is Jewish, the Kingdom which God promised to the nation of Israel in the Old Testament and is a literal Kingdom with a literal king upon a literal throne."[8] (Matt. 3:1-2; Hos. 1:4; Acts 1:6-8; Rev. 11:15)
        ii. "The Kingdom of God is inclusive in character, including: all who in any period believed God, the seed of Abraham, The Church, All who believe after the Tribulation."[9] (Rom. 14:17; Luke 17:20-21; 1 Cor. 4:20; 1 Cor. 15:50; John 3:3-5)

    b. **The Law of Full Mention**
        i. We have looked at the Laws of First Mention and Progressive Mention, but this principle is, "That principle by which God declares his full mind upon any subject vital to our spiritual life. Somewhere in the Word, God gathers together the scattered fragments that have to do with a particular truth, and puts them into one exhaustive statement. That is his full mind concerning that truth."[10]
            1. Examples — **Resurrection** (1 Corinthians 15); **Restoration of Israel** (Romans 11); **Faith Examples** (Hebrews 11); **The Church** (Ephesians 1); **Principles of the Kingdom of Heaven** (Matthew 5-7); **Righteousness by Faith** (Romans 3-4); **Charity/Love** (1 Corinthians 13); **Spiritual Gifts** (1 Corinthians 12); etc.

    c. **The Repetition Principle**
        i. The principle by which God repeats something already stated, in order to add to it, or to draw close attention to it. It is never done to "waste space".
            1. Examples:
                a. "Verily, Verily" (Jn. 5:24, 25; 6:26, 32, 47, 53; 8:34) —The statement means, "Truly, Truly". When he says it twice, it is meant to tell us to listen very closely.
                b. The Gospels — Four accounts of the Life of Jesus, all written to give us a different perspective of His life, not simply wasteful repeating of the same stories.
                c. Revelation — Four accounts of the events of the Tribulation, leading up to Jesus Second Coming.
                d. Kings/Chronicles — Both give the same basic telling of the events during this time in Israel/Judah, but from a different perspective. Many have noted that 1 and 2 Kings is mankind's perspective of these events, while 1 and 2 Chronicles is God's perspective of these events.

2. A Few More Tools to Use

    a. **Recommended Books**: *The Keys of Bible Stud*y (Mark Trotter); *Principles of Biblical Hermeneutics* (J. Edwin Hartill); *Bible Explorer's Guide* (John Phillips); *The Treasury of Scripture Knowledge* (R. A. Torrey edition); *Halley's Bible Handbook* (Henry H. Halley); *Willmington's Guide to the Bible* (Harold L. Willmington)
    b. **Recommended Bible Study Software**: *Blue Letter Bible (website and mobile app); Logos Bible Software (desktop, web, and mobile); e-Sword (Windows, Mac, Android, iPhone, and iPad); and SwordSearcher (Windows software).*
    c. **Recommended Audio Learning:** Mark Trotter's *Keys of Bible Study* is also available as a free 13-session WordStrong audio course (wordstrong.me). Also, on Apple Podcasts *WordStrong* channel.

[8] J. Edwin Hartill, *Principles of Biblical Hermeneutics* (CreateSpace Independent Publishing Platform, 2015), 41.
[9] J. Edwin Hartill, *Principles of Biblical Hermeneutics* (CreateSpace Independent Publishing Platform, 2015), 41.
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            1. Beyond this, going back to our Every Word factor: Are God and Heaven the same? Do we pray to Heaven? Do we live in God when we die?
            2. The Kingdom of God is a spiritual, inward kingdom entered through the new birth.

    b. **The Law of Full Mention**
        i. We have looked at the Laws of First Mention and Progressive Mention, but this principle is, "That principle by which God declares his full mind upon any subject vital to our spiritual life. Somewhere in the Word, God gathers together the scattered fragments that have to do with a particular truth, and puts them into one exhaustive statement. That is his full mind concerning that truth."[10]
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